Social Media for Catholic Churches

How to Post on Your Parish Facebook & Instagram Pages

Joe Jarrell

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This book is dedicated to my wife, Mikaella.

Thank you for your love, support, kindness, and faith in me. You make the work worth doing.

This book is also dedicated to my friends Father Nicholas Fleming and Father Igor de Bliquy, for their support and encouragement as I began this ministry.

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Introduction

Back in 2025, a Chesterton Academy opened up in town shortly after I moved to Visalia, California. One of the members of the board was a parishioner and knew me. Because I was a content creator, she asked me if I could help give them some guidance on how to grow on social media. I said of course. I like social media and marketing, and it's always fun to talk about things you're passionate about.

"Well Joe, we're really wanting to get more people to know about us. That way we can get more students registered at the school."

"Got it. Well, here's what I would do..." I talked for essentially the entire call. I shared how I post, the strategies I use, how to edit content, where to post. I reviewed their pages, shared my content dashboard, everything.

When I got off my soapbox, the Zoom call was pretty quiet.

"Well Joe, thank you so much. We really appreciate you taking some time to help us." The call ended shortly after that.

After the call, I felt...bummed. I don't think a lot of it landed. I overwhelmed them with tips, and when that happens your head starts spinning and you don't know where to start. Really, I felt guilty after the call because I knew in my heart I didn't help them get started, I likely paralyzed them with information-overload.

Why This Book Exists

That call taught me something very important. Most Catholic organizations do not need more random social media tips like I gave to the Chesterton Academy team. They do not need someone to jump on a Zoom call and firehose them with everything he knows about content, algorithms, editing, posting, captions, reels, stories, and ads (which is what I did). They really just need a simple, and proven, framework that any team can implement.

That is why I wrote this book.

See, most pastors know deep down that the parish should be using social media better. They know people are on Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, and TikTok. They know parishioners are scrolling every day. And, most importantly, they know younger families, young adults, fallen-away Catholics, and even their own regular Mass-goers are giving attention to these platforms. But social media is a whole ball of wax that seems intimidating to jump into.

So most parish teams usually end up doing one of three things. They ignore social media completely, or they post random announcements whenever they remember, or some try to do "good social media," but end up copying whatever businesses, influencers, or Protestant megachurches are doing, even if it does not really fit the Catholic parish. So, this book is meant to solve that problem.

It is not a book about becoming trendy or progressive. It is not a book about watering down the Faith, or making the pastors into influencers. It is simply a book about frameworks. More specifically, it is a book about helping Catholic parishes communicate in the places where people are already giving their attention.

If a parish has beautiful liturgies, faithful priests, strong ministries, generous parishioners, and events that could actually help people grow closer to Christ, then people should know about them. But that won't happen by accident. It happens when a parish learns how to reach people where they are, give value, build goodwill, and make clear asks that help people take the next step.

My goal for you as the reader is straightforward: to give you a practical social media system you can actually understand and use. Not theory for the sake of theory. And not tactics that change every six months. Rather, frameworks for using social media to increase engagement in parish life.

How This Book Is Structured

I structured this book in three parts.

- Section I explains the principles behind social media: giving and asking, attention, and the social media funnel.
- Section II explains organic social media: what to post, how to create content, and how to make better asks on Facebook and Instagram.
- Section III explains paid advertising: how parishes can use Meta ads to reach more local people, promote events, and get more volunteers.

Where I'm Coming From

I had my first experience with religion as a child. When I was around 10 years old, my parents allowed me to go to a Baptist church with my

uncle, who was very Christian. I would go to the services on Sunday, and Sunday school afterwards. But over time I stopped going for whatever reason, and religion essentially took a back seat in my life until my 20s. During my senior year of college, I started thinking a lot more about deeper questions. I had joined a fraternity my sophomore year, and it led me down a path where I wasn't very happy with myself by senior year. Low grades, drinking heavily, recreational drugs, and a lack of health. I was unhappy most days, so I started looking into things to fill the void. I found PragerU on YouTube, and then I found Ben Shapiro, and then Jordan Peterson.

The first book I ever read about "deeper things" was 12 Rules for Life by Jordan Peterson, which started me on the journey. After that, I read a Genesis commentary by Dennis Prager, and then one on Exodus. I also started attending a non-denominational church in town. But it wasn't until after graduation that I became interested in Catholicism.

A coworker of mine, we'll call him John, was a devout Catholic. So when we became close, he walked with me in my faith journey and helped me take my first steps into the Church. At first, that meant going with John to Mass before we went trap shooting. And then it was hanging out with some young adults from the parish. And before I knew it, I had signed up for RCIA and was watching Bishop Barron's "Catholicism" series on the Word on Fire website.

I was baptized into the Catholic Church on Easter of 2021 at the age of 25. By that point I had a deep interest in the Faith. Almost as soon as I converted, I was going on retreats and discerning the priesthood. My parents say that was because I get super into things for bursts of time, which I think is true. But with my faith it was different. It wasn't Jiu Jitsu or billiards, or another random hobby. It was a complete and utter philosophy and worldview on everything.

Most of all, a relationship with Christ began to unfold, which changed me completely. The fullness of the Faith was so astonishing to me. The rabbit holes you could go down with theology, philosophy, apologetics...I fell in love with it.

As this was going on in my mid-20s, I was a bit lost in what I wanted to do in my career. I had graduated from engineering school, but I didn't have a passion for it. At the time, I was working at a law firm writing technical documents, and it seemed the next logical step would be to go to law school and become a patent attorney. I didn't love this idea either, but I ended up going anyway.

During my first year of law school I reached a major turning point in my life.

Things got very busy and hectic for me: I was still discerning, and was going to Come & See retreats with the Dominicans in St. Louis during the school year. But I was also going to law school full-time. And I had a new hobby: fitness. So during the school year, I was training for a fitness competition. If that's not enough, I also decided to dabble in content creation on social media. As you can guess, nothing was getting my full attention. I placed 4th in the NPC Badger State Bodybuilding Competition, and didn't qualify for nationals. I got two Bs my first semester, and I was semi-dating a girl while I was discerning. Physically, mentally, and spiritually, I was drained.

By the grace of God, something unfortunate happened that allowed me to grow out of this hecticness, and find my purpose in life. At the time my social media content was quite amateurish—I said a lot about politics, values, and religion that was very controversial at the time—and the law firm I was working for saw it. Before I knew it, I got a call from a DEI officer who fired me from the law firm. On top of everything else, I was now jobless.

This sounds like rock bottom. But God has a funny sense of humor. After time in prayer, I realized that that firing was the culmination of months of indecision, of feeling stuck on a life path I didn't love and torn about what to do next. Honestly, it makes sense looking back. But losing my job became the last straw. I decided, "enough was enough." I was going to take control of my life.

I contacted my vocation director and told him that I felt called to marriage, which I had known was the case for some time. I canceled my NPC bodybuilding membership. And I dropped out of law school. I was going to live my own, authentic life.

I decided the path God wanted for me the most was to combine my passions in a way that helped people. The best way for me to do that, I realized, was to help other Catholic men get fit. I got to teach fitness, which I loved; I got to be in community with men who shared my values; and I built it all through social media, which I had a genuine interest in.

And it worked. Within 30 months, I built a seven-figure company. At the time of writing this, over 500 Catholic men have been helped, including 21 priests (19 diocesan and 2 religious). I became a Catholic "influencer" doing podcasts with Lila Rose, interviewing Michael Knowles and Father Mike Schmitz, and being invited as a guest speaker to Chesterton Academy galas. It was a dream come true, and still is.

But over the last year I've felt called to more. Fitness is great, but I found what I really have a deep passion for is growth. In business, in the Church, in myself, everything. After taking this thought to prayer, and numerous discussions in spiritual direction, I realized it's time to help on a greater scale.

And that's what led me to start Chapel Launch, a digital marketing and consulting agency for Catholic parishes, and to writing this book.

My hope is that this book helps your parish reach more people, increase engagement at events and liturgies, raise more support for ministry, encourage more vocations, and ultimately bring more souls into the sacramental life of the Church.

I hope you find it useful.

Section I: Concepts

Chapter One

Giving and Asking

Before I was Catholic, I had a friend at work named John.

We met in 2019, right after I graduated engineering school and started my first job writing patents at a law firm in Milwaukee, WI. At the time, I was still in my "live day by day" phase, and religion was not something I really thought about.

But John was different. He was sharp, he worked hard (always seeming to outbill me at the firm), and he seemed unusually put together for someone our age. But most of all, the biggest difference between us was that he was a devout Catholic who took his faith seriously.

That last one piqued my curiosity the most, because of how traditional his beliefs were. I would ask him questions like "wait so you're pro-life?" and he always seemed to have an answer and would respond calmly. Despite our disagreements about things at the time, we quickly became friends.

As time went on, we realized we actually had a lot in common. We both graduated from the same engineering school (Milwaukee School of Engineering), we both liked working out, and we both liked

shooting guns. And shooting guns in particular, as it turned out, was the beginning of my conversion to the Catholic faith.

One weekend in the fall of 2019, John had invited me to go shoot 5-Stand at a range south of Milwaukee. The range had a clubhouse with a bar, where you could go in and have a beer after you were done shooting. It was a great time as always. After a couple hours of shooting and drinking, we decided to pack up and get going.

As we were walking back to the car he asked, almost offhandedly, "Hey, do you want to come to Mass with me after this?"

I paused and mulled it over. I wasn't exactly giddy to go spend an hour of my Sunday in church. But I knew he always went. And he *did* pay for the gun range...

"Sure," I said.

And the rest is history. A year and a half later, on the Easter Vigil in 2021, I was received into the Catholic Church.

John played a *huge* role in my conversion. And I often wonder how my life would have been different if I said no that day (personally, I think the Holy Spirit would have brought me to the Church regardless). But in any case, I said yes.

See, John did something that made it significantly more likely for me to go to church with him that weekend: he did something nice for me first by paying for the gun range. *After* that, he asked me if I wanted to go to Mass with him. That nice gesture was the little nudge that I needed to say "yes" that Sunday, and my conversion snowballed from there.

It turns out people are much more likely to do what you ask them, if you first do something nice for them.

Give *Then* Ask

The entire book is centered around the following idea: we want to give first, and then ask people to do things.

I'm guessing you opened this book because you want to increase engagement at your church. You want more attendance at events and liturgies, you want more volunteers to help at the parish, or you want more in giving to do more ministry work. My goal in this book is to show you that those things are all available to you if you *give first*.

To put it plainly, to maximize engagement at a parish, you want to:

1. Give first

2. Then ask

Simple, I know, but it works. Let's break down each of these two steps.

Give First...

After I dropped out of law school in 2023, the first business I ever started was a fitness coaching business for Catholic men. There was only one problem: I had no idea how to build one of those. And I knew I had to figure it out quickly, or I'd have to go back to my parents, tail between my legs, and say, "You were right. I'll go back to school," which was the last thing I wanted to do.

Luckily, as I was researching how to start a business, I found a podcast from a man named Brian Mark called the "Change Lives" podcast. Brian was this 30-something Instagram guru who seemed to know a lot about fitness businesses and helping them grow. He had over 100,000 followers on Instagram, and he ran a business that helped fitness trainers build businesses. I shot him a message thanking him for his content, and he sent me a link to his podcast for some more resources.

Now this podcast was a gold mine. It was all about how fitness coaches can start a small business in 10 minute bite-sized episodes, and I binged it like crazy. It had episodes like "How to Sell a Fitness Package" or "What to Say to People Interested in Your Program." I consumed that podcast at least an hour a day, and sure enough it got me my first ever 10 fitness clients. I was able to pay rent and buy groceries all on my own. I couldn't believe it.

Now here's the interesting part: I hadn't paid Brian Mark *anything*. I mean podcasts are free, right? But Brian had solved so many problems for me already, I almost felt *compelled* to pay him. And sure enough, when I saw an advertisement from his account that offered one-on-one business coaching with him a couple months later, I bought it.

Now, would I have given money to Brian *right after* I dropped out of school? Probably not. He hadn't done anything for me. I didn't know who he was, and so had I felt no sense of goodwill towards him. But after helping me solve all of those initial problems, I felt a tremendous sense of goodwill towards him, and ended up paying him $6,000 for his beginning coaching program. So, my goodwill towards Brian was increased when Brian gave me valuable information that solved problems for me.

To put it plainly, goodwill is increased when you provide something valuable to a person, like solving my problem of how to get fitness clients. Because solving problems for people is valuable, this is often called "giving value" to a person. Therefore, another way we can say this is the following: **goodwill is increased when you give value**.

But why does this happen?

Why Giving Increases Goodwill

In 1985, Ethiopia was one of the most—if not the most—destitute countries in the world. Complete abject poverty, and an economy in ruins, and thousands dying each year from disease and starvation. However, despite this, Ethiopia sent a relief check to Mexico in '85 to help the victims of that year's earthquakes in Mexico City. If you're thinking that Ethiopia should have gotten their house in order first before doling out relief checks, I would agree with you. So why on earth did they send money across the world when their country was on the brink of collapse?

Well it turns out that half a century earlier, in 1935, Mexico had sent *Ethiopia* relief funds when Ethiopia was invaded by Italy.

No more digging needs to be done. Ethiopia was following the age-old rule of human psychology: we tend to repay good deeds that were done for us.

Did you know that universities have tested this rule by sending holiday cards to strangers, and the majority of people send one back? And in a famous psychology study, a researcher did a small favor for participants by bringing them a soda. Later, those participants were twice as likely to comply with a request to buy raffle tickets, even if they didn't particularly like the researcher. Did you know restaurants have found that when servers gave diners one small mint with the check, tips increased? And when the server gave one mint, walked away, then returned and said, "Actually, here's another one," tips jumped up to 20%?

All of these stories highlight a certain law of human nature, called The Rule of Reciprocity. The Rule of Reciprocity is this: **people feel a sense of obligation to repay good deeds that were done for them.** I wanted to repay Brian for helping me get 10 clients. People wanted to send holiday cards back to repay the kind gesture. Subjects in the psychology study wanted to buy raffle tickets to repay the free

gift of a soda. And diners wanted to tip higher to repay the gift of a mint.

This Rule probably stems from thousands of years of people wanting to be "in community" since it does not bode well for humans when they take from the group, and don't give back. In any case, the point is that we understand the rule and know it exists.

However, there is a caveat to The Rule of Reciprocity: the good deed cannot have strings attached. It's not really a virtuous, good deed if you have ulterior motives for why you're doing the good deed. True charity, as we know, is love *for their sake*. You don't want anything in return. You just want them to receive the good deed so it makes them have a better life.

Let's explore an example of a good deed "with strings attached."

If you travel around the Vatican, the Spanish Steps, or even the Colosseum in Rome, Italy, you'll no doubt run into foreigners holding trinkets. If you wander too close to them, they will attempt to hand you one of their trinkets. When you try to return it, they will say things like "it's my gift to you." They make it very difficult for you to return it, but they will say "Please, something for me is appreciated."

Now you're torn. You don't want the stupid trinket. But they won't let you return it, and the Rule of Reciprocity is keeping you stuck. It would be so easy to walk away, but thousands of years of evolution makes it hard to take another step.

With a sigh of resignation, you keep the trinket, hand him €5, and walk down the street, throwing the trinket in the first garbage can you see.

Unlike the other examples, the reason the trinket scam feels, well, like a scam, is because there are strings attached. If you try to walk away without paying, the scammers will follow you until you give the trinket back. If you try to give the trinket back, they say no.

Reflecting back to my earlier story, I know in my heart John didn't take me to the gun range *to guarantee* I come to Mass with him. It was a kind gesture, with no strings attached. It just so happens that genuine generosity makes people more open to future invitations, like going to Mass.

To me, this is the most ethical way to ask for things in life: help someone first for their sake, and then ask. The alternative is you just ask people to do things all the time without giving them anything, which is essentially begging. Begging works, I suppose, but you certainly get lower compliance, and the worst part is you don't get to do good deeds for people! A wasted opportunity to exercise charity.

Think about it. You can truly give things to people that help them, with no strings attached. And then for your ministry, when you ask for attendance to an event, or for volunteers, or donations, people are far more likely to respond positively to your asks. And that additional engagement allows you to do even *more* things to help people. Which *again* leads to more engagement. It's truly a win-win.

In short, we want to give value to people first with no strings attached before we ever ask for anything, because it increases the goodwill they feel towards us. And because of the Rule of Reciprocity, they will feel a sense to repay that goodwill in the future.

...Then Ask

My wife, Mikaella, is from central California, and so I left the Midwest in 2025 and moved to "Cali." As it turned out, she and her family were part of one of the largest parishes in the United States, and attended the largest Catholic church in North America (St. Charles Borromeo). I saw several familiar faces, waved as I walked in, genuflected, and

found my seat. On Sundays, I sit with the whole family–wife, in-laws, etc.–so we usually grab a pew for ourselves.

The Mass started out like any other. During the offertory, the ushers followed the standard practice of walking up, bowing, and started making their way past the pews collecting donations. However, something unique happened. Prior to the final blessing, I noticed that the ushers were walking down the aisles *again*. They had the collection baskets in their hand once again, and were extending them into the pews to collect donations a second time.

I felt...odd. My sister-in-law saw my look. "What, they want more donations?" I whispered, half-jokingly.

"I guess..." she responded.

I made no movement to grab my wallet. As the usher approached our pew, instead of the typical don't-make-eye-contact-with-the-usher strategy when you're not placing money in the collection basket, I made eye contact with him but didn't reach for my wallet. I was frustrated. And I noticed something interesting: as the basket approached my pew, I saw that significantly fewer donations had been placed in the basket than the first time around.

The whole experience left me feeling a bit agitated. After Mass, I asked a few other parishioners what they thought...Most responses were the same:

"Yeah...I hear you, they probably just need more donations. St. Charles costs a lot I hear."

"Yeah, I didn't love it either. I heard it's for winter maintenance though."

The majority of people I spoke with felt a similar feeling: that yes, they understood that the parish could use more donations, but didn't love being asked twice at Mass.

Why was that?

The Goodwill Meter

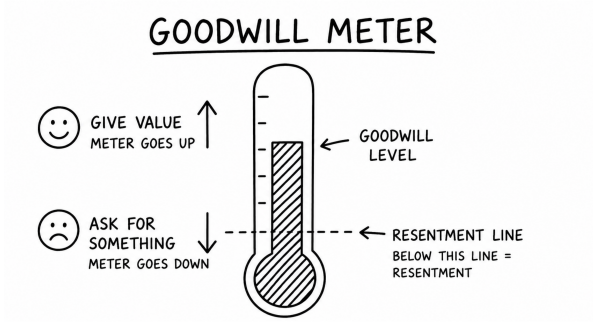
It's an interesting dynamic when it comes to asking. When we want more of something, we think the solution is to ask more. A second collection basket at the end of Mass, for example. But at the same time, if we ask for something too often, it can become problematic. We know this deep down, because if the answer to more donations at a parish for example, was really just, "ask more," then why stop at two collection baskets? Ask 20 times per Mass. But a part of you probably thinks, "Eh, I don't think that's a good idea." Right. Something tells us that's *too much asking*.

If X (formerly Twitter) showed you ads every other post, your feelings toward the platform would start to become negative. If your favorite YouTube channel did ad-reads every 60 seconds, you would unsubscribe. If every time your cousin came to visit for family gatherings he asked you for money, you'd think he was extremely annoying.

So, we know there's a correlation between how often someone is asked for/to do something, and their feelings towards the people asking. If you ask too often, people get frustrated. And if you don't ask too often, people seem fine.

In other words: **asking has a cost, and the cost is goodwill.**

I like to imagine there's a big "goodwill meter" that's filled with my audience's goodwill. As we learned earlier, if I do a good deed for someone that helps them, the goodwill meter goes up. But anytime I ask them for something, the goodwill meter goes down.



And if I ask *too* much and the goodwill meter gets *too* low, feelings of resentment and frustration will arise in my audience. On this meter, I like to imagine a line near the bottom called the Resentment Line where this happens. As long as you can keep the goodwill high enough to where it is always above the Resentment Line, you'll never have to worry about asking too often, or feeling pushy.

That's what happened to me at that Mass that day. I felt like I had been asked too often, and my goodwill decreased to a point where I became a bit frustrated, and I no longer wanted to give more in donations. Whether my feelings were justified, I *felt* it. And when you're dealing with people doing things (especially handing over money) feelings are everything.

I could have been a stand-out case, but likely not. In my own experience, I've spoken to ushers from other parishes that do two collection baskets, and the results are the same: way less money is donated in the second collection.

Now the pastor might say, "Well the second collection is for a different reason. It's for the winter maintenance fund, the diocese, the Sisters of...etc." And that may be true. But to the parishioner, it's the

same. Regardless of the *reason* for the ask, it was still two asks, which means two withdrawals from the goodwill meter.

The pastor might also say, “Well, hey at least we got something in that second basket.” But it's important to remember that asking *costs goodwill,* every single time. So the question is not, "did we get some returns for our ask?" The question is whether the juice is really worth the squeeze. Was the return *worth* the goodwill lost? Most of the time when asking multiple times in a row, it is not.

How Often Should You Ask?

Unsurprisingly, people who have wanted success have pushed the limits of this question: how often can I ask for things, without upsetting my audience? We need look no further than our smartphones.

If you pull out your phone right now, open your favorite social media app, and begin scrolling, you’ll see something interesting. Every three-four posts, almost to a T, is an advertisement. A family photo from your uncle, a Father Mike Schmitz video, a workout tip, and then...an ad for the Hallow App. And the cycle repeats. This is the case on YouTube, Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, etc.

That's the foundation of our answer. As a general rule of thumb, you want to give at least three times as much as you ask. Give three things, ask once. Gary Vee, a world-renowned marketer, calls this ratio “Jab, Jab, Jab, Right Hook” and wrote a bestselling book on the concept, titled the same.

In social media, it's very easy to track the ratio of "gives" to "asks." First you show 3 entertaining posts, then one advertisement. But in the real world, it's a bit fuzzy. Just know, that the more you give (and increase the goodwill meter), the more you can ask (and decrease the goodwill meter) without upsetting your audience.

Some Asks Cost More Than Others

Some asks don't cost much in goodwill. But some do. And knowing which is which can be important, especially if you want to avoid the Resentment Line.

For example, asking parishioners to make a financial donation, right then and there, costs a lot in goodwill. On the other hand, asking parishioners to subscribe to an e-bulletin with their email costs a lot less.

Here is a story to illustrate this. One time I went to a presentation of a marketing guru on something involving Facebook advertising. I had never met him before, and thus was at "zero" in terms of goodwill towards him.

He gave his hour-long presentation, and it was extremely helpful. I learned a bunch of information, and got really excited about getting back to my work to implement everything. At the end of the presentation, I expected a big ask. After all, he had built up a lot of goodwill for me, so it would not have been unreasonable for him to ask the room to buy his book or consulting package.

Instead, he simply said, "I'm glad this was helpful. Now I'm not going to stand up here and sell you anything. All I ask is that if you have a question, you raise your hand and ask it, because many others might have the same question and it will help them out."

So his "ask" was just to have my questions answered! How great is that? After we all left, we each had extremely high goodwill towards him, and it wasn't "withdrawn," so to speak. So if he were to ask me to buy something in the future, now that he has so much goodwill built with me, I would be much more willing to buy.

I'll give a story with a different outcome. One time I wanted to create a nice "About" page for the website for my online community. It was a fitness community for Catholic men. I came across this one man, Jason, who was recommended to me as someone who specialized in this sort of thing. So I messaged him, sent him my current About page, and asked if he'd be keen to hop on a call. Jason agreed, we hopped on, and he began giving me some tips on how he could improve the page. Nothing major.

We then got to the pricing conversation, and I asked him how much it was.

"30,000 for the entire page," he said.

I was shocked. And, frankly, a little frustrated. You want me to give you thirty grand right now? For a freaking website page?

He had given me very little to build any goodwill, and then made a tremendous ask. It resulted in me falling below the Resentment Line, and, accordingly, I did not work with him. So before you ask, always have a sense of how much goodwill it's going to cost.

The Bottom Line

The core concept in this book is the relationship between giving and asking. We can "give" and do good deeds for people—help them solve problems for example, like Brian's content did for me—and increase the goodwill they feel towards us. As the goodwill increases, they will feel a sense to repay that goodwill in the future. If and when we "ask" them if they want to do something (e.g., attend, subscribe, volunteer, donate, etc.), they are therefore more likely to respond positively.

However, asking people for things must be done with prudence, because it costs goodwill every time we ask. At a minimum, we want to make sure we're giving at least three times as much as we're asking.

In addition, we want to make sure we're being efficient with our asks (more on what that means later).

To summarize, if you want to maximize engagement at your Catholic parish, give abundantly to your parishioners with no strings attached. Serve them, help them solve problems, and build up goodwill over time. Then, when you ask them to attend, volunteer, or give, make the ask clear and efficient so the goodwill you have built is not wasted.

Key Takeaways

- To maximize engagement, you want to give first, then ask.
- This is because doing a good deed for someone increases their goodwill towards you, and the Rule of Reciprocity makes them feel a sense to repay the good deed.
- The curious thing about asking is that it has a cost, and that cost is goodwill.
- Ideally, we want to give a lot, and ask efficiently.

Chapter Two

Why Social Media?

At this point, you may be wondering: *This book is called Social Media for Catholic Churches, so why have we spent so much time talking about psychology? What does any of this have to do with Facebook or Instagram?*

My Realization About Social Media

In February of 2023, I was in my second semester of law school at Marquette. But by that time, I hated it. The legal world was quite secular, and even a private Catholic school such as Marquette's getting affected. To make matters worse, this was already my third or fourth career jump and I was already 25. First, I went to engineering school, and then I worked at a law firm, and then I left to work at Milwaukee Tool, and then I left to go to law school. Sooner or later I needed to figure my life out. I was running out of jumps.

As the semester dragged on, I was occupying my time more and more with my newest hobby: fitness. There was a bodybuilding show in Madison, Wisconsin in April, and I was determined to do well. I still

attended class and did my homework, but all my free time was spent on a treadmill or eating chicken.

As the show date got closer and closer, I was starting to realize I really had no interest in law. I enjoyed reading, sure, but reading and interpreting case law did not interest me. What did, was getting big muscles (at least at the time). I figured that the best thing for me to do was to stop going down this legal path and go after something I loved. So I decided to become a fitness coach. I didn't fully understand how to do fitness coaching yet, but I just knew I had to leave school and go for it.

I booked a meeting with the dean, and told them I'm dropping out. And it felt amazing.

That was the easy part, though.

The first year of law school was a fat $30,000, and I dumped most of my money into the tuition to actually enroll. So with no job, rent due, and little in the bank account, it was time to figure out fitness coaching, and fast. All I had so far was a dream and a six-pack.

To start, I assumed that if I wanted people to sign up for what I was doing, they would let me know. I told my friends, and my family, and yet I still had zero customers.

Then something interesting happened. The next week, right before one of my last classes in Property Law (I figured I'd finish out the semester), I was listening to an interview with Bishop Robert Barron. He was being interviewed on the growth of Word on Fire, and his message to the Catholic world about digital ministry.

And he said something that hit me like a brick wall: "Most people today, especially young people, live on the internet and on social media... The great missionaries and evangelists in the history of the Church went where people were... We can no longer expect people to come to our institutions; we have to move into their space."

That's it, I thought. I have to go where people are!

I realized I was thinking about this completely backward. I was waiting for people to come to me, when the entire culture had already moved somewhere else: to social media. If I wanted people to engage with my service, I had to go where *they* already were. Not where I wished they were.

It made so much sense. I made a new standard: I *had* to learn how to reach people on social media.

So I made a simple plan.

That same day, I posted a picture of myself after the gym with a motivational quote on Instagram. I had no marketing funnel built, or any plan afterwards, I just made the post. But it got a couple likes, and the fire had started.

Three years and 1,000 posts later, that decision turned into a seven-figure online fitness coaching business for Catholic men, built entirely through social media. It also led me to meeting Father Mike Schmitz, meeting Michael Knowles, being invited as a guest on Lila Rose's podcast, and speaking at Newman Centers and Chesterton Galas around the country.

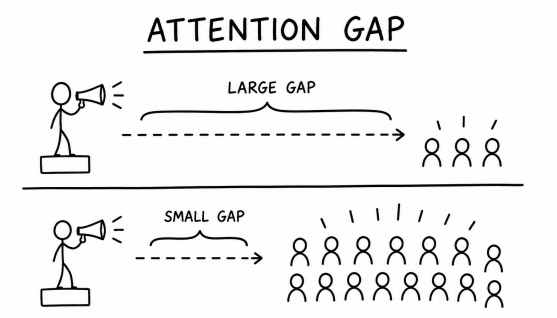
Things got a lot better. I paid off my student loans, moved to California, and used the capital to fund other businesses. But more importantly, I figured out the fundamental rule in how to engage people. **You have to go to where they are**.

Why It Worked

If I'm trying to ask a group of people to do something, I want to ask them in a place where they all hear it. Similarly, if I'm trying to do a good deed for my audience, I want to do it in a place where they all receive it and consume it.

Social media happens to be a place where *a lot* of people hang out and give their attention to. Recent estimates suggest that Americans spend over 2 hours per day, on average, on social media. This means—when you do social media correctly—there's a very good chance that when you talk to the people in your audience on social media, a lot of them hear it.

I call this concept an "attention gap." **The attention gap is the portion of your audience that is not paying attention on the platform you are using.**



If you were to go on the local radio station tomorrow and announce the upcoming celebration for your parish's patronal feast day next week, few (if any) parishioners would hear it and come to the event. This is because there is a *massive* attention gap in local radio today. Attention simply isn't there anymore. But, if you made that local radio announcement in 1985, a bunch of people would hear it! The attention gap would be way smaller. Or, similarly, if you made a newspaper ad in 1965.

See, where your audience puts their attention shifts. And right now, attention has shifted massively to social media; it has a very small attention gap. Now we simply want to follow where people go, and do

our communication there. That way when we give value, more people receive it. And when we ask for things, more people hear the ask, and the asks become more efficient.

And there's really no two ways about it. For your parishioners, Americans, and the world as a whole, attention is on social media.

"Ok," you might think. "I get that people are on social media, but I don't think it's *that* big of a deal." I used to think that too. But I want to share with you a story of how a man's entire life changed from one simple video on TikTok.

In the fall of 2020, Nathan Apodaca's car broke down on his way to work. So he hopped on his skateboard, drank Ocean Spray cranberry juice, and filmed himself cruising while listening to "Dreams" by Fleetwood Mac.

The video ended up going viral. But not just viral. The video went *turbo-viral*.

Nathan's video got over 100 million views. Ocean Spray cranberry juice sold out around the country. "Dreams" by Fleetwood Mac tripled in sales, and doubled in streams, placing it back on major charts. Ocean Spray saw such a massive surge in growth that

they decided to thank Nathan by buying him a brand-new, cranberry-red truck filled with bottles of cranberry juice. Mick Fleetwood, the drummer of Fleetwood Mac, personally recreated the video on TikTok at age 73. He even said Nathan "made Dreams relevant again" and called the video "a blessing."

As for Nathan, he gained millions of followers, signed brand deals, appeared in commercials, performed at events, and even walked the red carpet at the Grammy Awards.

All because of a 23-second TikTok video.

The New Public Square

I believe social media is the new public square and the new public bazaar. Recent estimates suggest there are over 5 billion active social media users worldwide, and the average global user spends about 2 hours and 30 minutes per day on these platforms.

Think about it. Imagine someone makes a helpful video about baking sourdough bread. If they share it by text and on a small local blog, maybe 15 people see it. But if they post it on Instagram and it reaches 500,000 people, the same piece of value now has dramatically more impact. And if that person later creates a cookbook, the ask is being made to a much larger audience.

I'm not saying you need to go viral. But there I am unaware of another other place—at least, as of writing this in 2026—where you can reach all of your parishioners on a medium that they actually spend time on. Between Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok, you can reach a massive portion of your parishioners on platforms they already use.

Following the Trailblazers

What I'm advocating for is simple: we should spread the Word on whatever medium currently has the smallest attention gap. We are called to go where people are. If the attention gap of the people is lowest on social media, then that is where the Gospel should be proclaimed. If we want to evangelize effectively, we must speak where ears are already listening.

And to be honest, we're not the first Catholics to do this. Saint Maximilian Kolbe was radically ahead of his time. He founded Niepokalanów, which became the largest Catholic publishing operation in the world at the time. And in the 1950s, Bishop Fulton J. Sheen brought the Catholic Faith to prime-time television with the show *Life Is Worth Living*. The Church has always used the most powerful tools available to proclaim Christ. Today, that tool happens to be social media.

In the end, it's all about attention. If you want to communicate with people, serve them, invite them, and ultimately lead them closer to Christ, you have to start by speaking where they are already listening. Every generation has had its own public square, whether it was the Roman forum, the printing press, radio, television, or the local newspaper. Today, that public square is social media. And as we'll discuss in later chapters, the Church does not need to become worldly to use it well. She simply needs to do what she has always done, which is enter the places where people gather and proclaim Christ there. If your parish wants to engage more people in parish life, the first step is to simply close the attention gap. Go where your people already are.

Key Takeaways

- The attention gap is the portion of your audience that isn't paying attention on the platform you're using.
- Social media is one of the best tools for giving value and making asks efficiently because it has one of the lowest attention gaps of any major communication medium right now.
- Social media has one of the lowest attention gaps because billions of people use it daily, and the average user spends hours per day on social platforms.

Chapter Three

Social Media At Its Core

Before we go any further, it is important to understand that social media has two sides: organic and paid. Organic social media is the free content you post on Facebook and Instagram. Paid advertising is content you pay to show to a specific audience based on things like age, location, interests, or behavior. This chapter is the final high-level chapter before we get practical. Section II will focus on organic social media. Section III will focus on paid advertising. For now, we just need to understand the basic system both sides operate within.

When I Learned What Social Media Is

When I was building up my fitness business back in 2024, I was struggling to find more Catholic men who wanted to join the program. I would post content on my social media, but it didn't seem to be working. And I had recently purchased a brand new coaching software that was quite expensive, so I had to figure out how to get more clients

soon. I figured that the missing link in my system was that I was not running advertisements. So after a few quick searches online, I found a guru named Jeremy Pouge who specialized in Facebook and Instagram Ads for online coaches.

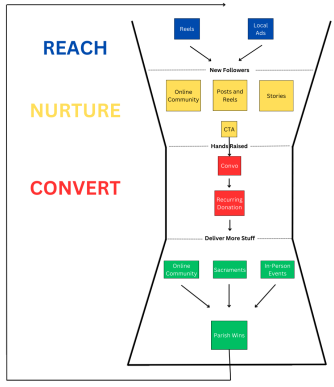
Perfect. I set up the call.

"I don't really do traditional sales calls," he said. "So it's $8,000, paid in advance. I'll teach you everything I know about Instagram and advertising."

I mulled it over. I was single, living in a small apartment in Milwaukee, and working in a booth at Panera Bread most days, because they had free coffee refills. How much worse could it get?

"Let's do it. Send me the invoice."

The next day, we hopped on a Zoom call and he pulled up a PDF graphic. I still have it, and have copied it below.



“Here’s the main thing you need to understand,” he said. “Social media is a funnel.”

At the top were strangers. These were people who first discovered me through ads or organic content. In the middle were the people who

started seeing more of my content and began to know, like, and trust me. At the bottom were the people who were ready for an ask.

He basically explained it in a single sentence: "Some people you reach will become nurtured. Some people you nurture will become ready to respond."

And that clicked with me. **Social media is just one big funnel with three sections, reach, nurture, and convert.** After my call with Jeremy, I felt like I finally understood what I was doing on social media, and I got to work.

Six months later, I made $100,000 in one month. I was able to pay for a trip to Rome, my wedding, and my move to California all due to me understanding and implementing this core concept. But even more than that, I felt like I was actually posting on social media with a purpose, instead of just posting randomly and hoping for the best.

The 3-Step Social Media Funnel

Even though a Catholic parish isn't selling anything like I was, its social media page will still act as a funnel. It's just funneling people for a different goal: engagement. As long as you follow the process, Catholics (and hey maybe some non-Catholics) will come to the page from the top, slide down after being nurtured, and convert out the bottom by engaging (e.g., attendance, volunteering, or giving).

Catholic organizations already use this system well. Ascension gives away *Bible in a Year* for free. Word on Fire gives away Bishop Barron's videos, podcasts, and clips for free. That free content reaches people and nurtures them over time. Then, when those same people are invited to buy a Bible, register for a program, donate, or attend an event, they are far more likely to respond because trust has already been built.

If we were to boil this process down, it would be three steps:

1. **Reach** TONS of people;

2. **Nurture** A LOT of those people; and

3. **Convert** SOME of those people by asking.

First, you **reach** people. Before people can be nurtured by your parish, they have to know your parish exists online. That means some of your content should be designed simply to get in front of new people.

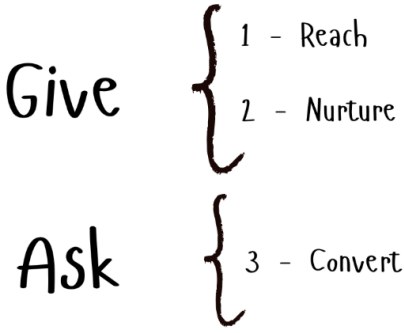
Second, you **nurture** a lot of those people. Nurturing your audience is similar to dating. A man usually cannot walk up to a woman he just met and ask her to be his girlfriend. He has to introduce himself first, build rapport, make her laugh, go on dates, and earn trust. Then he can ask her to be his girlfriend. It's the same scenario here. You don't want to blast an email out to everyone asking for more donations. First you want to make them aware you're online, provide a bunch of content about spirituality and the parish so they warm up to you, THEN you can ask them to increase giving.

Finally, you **convert** some of those nurtured people by asking them for things. "Convert" in this sense doesn't mean bringing them to the Catholic faith. Converting, in marketing, simply means getting them to comply with the ask. If you ask people to donate and five people donate, you got five *conversions* from that ask.

Now, why do we want to ask the people that have been nurtured? Because they're the ones with the most goodwill built up towards us! Remember back to Chapter 1? After you give them so much helpful content, they will have tremendous goodwill towards you, and the Rule of Reciprocity will make them significantly more likely to comply with the ask. And since every ask costs goodwill, asking where these people are is the most efficient place to ask. We're not wasting the

ask—and wasting goodwill—on asking people that aren't warmed up to us.

This is where the ideas from Chapter 1 connect to social media. Reach and nurture are both forms of giving. When a parish posts helpful or encouraging content, it gives value and builds goodwill. Then, when the parish eventually asks people to attend, volunteer, register, or give, that ask lands on warmer ground.



With all of this in mind, let's break down the frameworks for how you're going to reach, nurture, and convert people.

Step #1 – Reach people.

When I started helping Catholic churches with social media in 2026, I started doing it for free. Mainly because I didn't have proof of concept yet. I was still figuring things out, so when I told my first church that I could help them, I said, "I'll do it for free, and if it works great, and if it doesn't, well, you didn't lose any money."

They agreed.

This church in particular—Ss John and James Parish—had no Instagram account, and a dead Facebook page they hadn't posted to in over a year. I was basically starting from scratch digitally, so I need to figure out how to reach all the local parishioners quickly.

I started doing what most Instagram accounts do: post videos. And it worked, to a point. We were getting followers for the parish Instagram page, but not as much as we would like. I had to figure out a better strategy.

And then it dawned on me: I had helped my sister-in-law run some local ads for their gym a few months ago. In addition to that, I had ran something called "follower ads" for my own business. Basically, I ran ads asking people to follow me on Instagram.

"I wonder if I could combine the local advertising with my follower ads," I thought. "That way the parish could get a bunch of people locally to start following the page, and they'd already begin with a lot of reach."

I ran my idea past the parish and they said I can give it a shot. Great.

I built out a non-profit business portfolio for the parish on Meta, connected the parish Facebook and Instagram pages, set up a Meta Ads Manager account, put a credit card on file, and created the ad. I was ready to post. Here goes nothing.

I turned on the ad, and went to sleep. When I woke up, Mikaella, my wife, asked me what was going on with parish social media page.

"What happened?" I asked.

"The page gained like 100 followers last night."

I checked myself. Sure enough, over a hundred people local to the parish had started to follow the parish Instagram page, *overnight*. I checked the ads numbers, and sure enough the ad was doing well. $0.60 per click, a great return for a follower ad.

I realized that **to reach people on social media, you can't wait around for them to find you, you have to go where they are and force their attention.** In only 10 hours, the parish had reached a significant number of people. Everyone was happy. And I was particularly happy, because I finally found a way for parishes to reach parishioners online.

Techniques for Reaching People

There are two main techniques for reaching people organically (i.e., not paying for advertising). One way is to tell your parishioners you're on social media. The other is to post reels on social media. You can also reach people with paid advertising, like the follower ads I ran in the example above.

Let's break each one down.

Technique #1 – Tell the Parish You're on Social Media

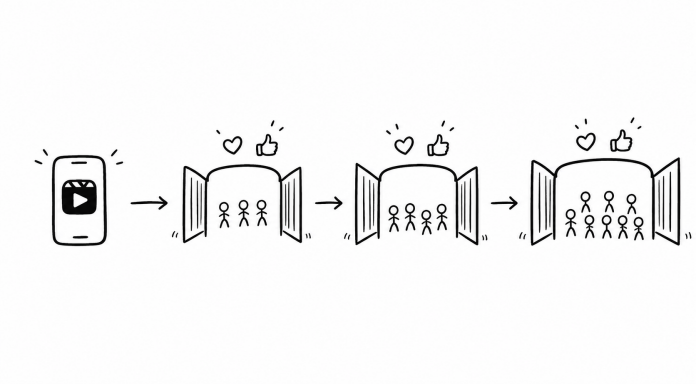
You don't have to start from scratch; you already have hundreds of people at your parish who would already want to follow the parish on social media. Tap into existing marketing channels to get the page off the ground. The two main mediums I recommend are:

- Telling the parish in the bulletin
- Telling the parish via email

By "tell" I also mean a gentle ask to get them to follow the page. For example, a flyer in the bulletin with a simple QR code to the Facebook page asking them to follow "to stay updated and receive free spiritual content" is sufficient.

Technique #2 – Posting Reels on Facebook and Instagram

The other technique you can use to reach people is simply by posting social media content, particularly reels (or short-form videos). Here's why this works. When you post a reel on social media, it generally gets sent to about 100 people: half are strangers and half are familiar with your content. Depending on how engaging the video is with those people, the next "gate" will open and it will send it to more people: more strangers and more people familiar with your content. And so on. This is the foundation of how short-form videos are shown on social media platforms.



So simply by the act of posting videos, you're going to reach new people. Now some of these new people will be local Catholics, but some won't be. And that's okay. Having people follow you that aren't exactly your ideal audience is still beneficial for the parish, for a couple reasons.

First, people who have a following are generally going to be considered more of an authority. If a person stumbles onto the Instagram page of the parish, and it has 30,000 followers, the person is going to think "Oh wow, these guys are legit." That will automatically make them more comfortable complying with your asks.

Second, it's important to remember that somebody does not have to be a member of your parish to comply with an ask. Personally, I've donated to Catholic parishes I'm not a parishioner of, just because I like the pastor and what he's doing. As your audience grows, non-parishioners will still be affected by The Rule of Reciprocity, and they will feel an obligation to repay the value you've given them. Leveraging donations through social media allows for this.

Technique #3 – Running Ads

I'll wait until Section III to dive deeper into ads, but at a high level, the example above was for a follower ad, which is simply where you make a post asking people to follow you and you pay to run it as an ad in your local area. This works well to increase your followers.

Step #2 – Nurture People

I knew for some years that my mission in life was to help Catholic churches with their engagement. There was only one minor hiccup: I had built my entire personal brand and business around me helping Catholic men with fitness. So if I was going to start my new endeavor with churches, I needed to distance myself from what I was currently doing.

So, I came up with a plan. I was going to pull my face out of the fitness business, and use all of my following and brand to reach out to Catholic churches. The fitness business would run off of advertisements from a business account, and "Joe Jarrell" would be free to post church engagement content. Time to execute.

After 5 months, it ended up being a disaster. I lost $50,000. I had to let three people go, one of which was a single mother. I was stressed, confused, and frankly irritated. I was working *more* and

things were getting worse. Catholic men that were wanting fitness help were showing up to consultations with more attitude, and less respect. They were sassy, flaky, and a little rude. On top of that, significantly less people were signing up with us. I had to get to the bottom of this, or things were going to disastrous real quick.

I decided to reach out to a friend of mine, Peyton. He helps wedding photographers grow their businesses, and is very successful at it. I explained the situation, and hopped on a call with him.

"Well this sucks," he said.

"Yeah...what's the move?" I asked him.

"I mean that's up to you. But this situation tells us one thing for sure. These guys joined the fitness program because they liked *you*. They don't care about the business."

"Yeah, but I'm running the same ads, same marketing material. Aren't the results what they want? I have proof we know what we're doing."

"I'm sure you do. But you're forgetting that people make buying decisions based on emotion. And they had an emotional connection with you. Now they just see some business ad popping up on their feed. It's different."

I was silent. I understood what he was saying, and the big mistake I made. **It's not enough to just reach people and convert them. I need to get them to connect with me.**

The relationship is built in the "nurturing" section, and I had essentially removed that from my system. And I paid dearly for it.

After realizing my mistake, I got to work on putting my face back into the content and in the ads for the fitness business. Shortly thereafter, things started to improve, both on the balance sheet and for my peace of mind.

Know, Like, Trust: How We Actually Nurture

We have talked about a couple concepts already when it comes to social media. There's the high-level Giving/Asking concept, where we want to give before we ask. That's the foundation of this book. There's also the Reach/Nurture/Convert concept that explains how social media works like a giant funnel. That's the system we're working within.

Regarding the latter concept, I want to explain what "Nurture" really means. What does it actually mean to nurture an audience member or "warm them up?" It makes sense there is a bit more nuance when it comes to nurturing, because this is where all the *work* is done. We initially reach people, that makes sense. And at the end we ask people to do things and they comply, that also makes sense. It's the black box in the middle where hearts and minds are changed, which can be mysterious. How *do* we get parishioners to want to actually volunteer more? Or attend events more often? Or become a generous giver? The way that is done is with nurturing. So here is the definition: **nurturing means getting the person to know, like, and trust us.**

The truth is, you want all three if you're asking people to do things, otherwise compliance will plummet. So, you have to make content that gets people to know, like, and trust you.

Let's look at one content type we've discussed: value content. It's true that giving value nurtures our audience. But giving value doesn't *entirely* nurture our audience. Here's why: if you only posted homily clips of the pastor giving spiritual advice on the parish page, that doesn't make the viewer really *know* much about the parish, or *trust* that people are having a fun time at events. All that type of content does is solve problems for the viewer, which makes people *like* you. It's only one slice—albeit a big slice—of the nurture pie.

The general rules of getting your audience to know, like, and trust you can be summarized as follows:

If the content helps solve a problem for the person, it makes them like you.

If the content shares something personal about you or the parish, it makes them know you.

If the content shows desirable results from something, it makes them trust you.

In later chapters, I'll explain the specific examples of content to post that aligns to each of these three. For now, it's just important to understand the concept of how to actually nurture. Next we'll discuss where nurturing is actually done on social media.

Two Ways to Nurture

We can nurture in two main ways:

1. More Videos & Posts

2. Stories & Going Live

<u>Way #1 – More Videos & Posts.</u>

When Charlie Kirk was assassinated in 2025, it shook millions of people. I remember exactly where I was and what I was doing. My wife Mikaella was distraught over it for several days.

Why did so many people feel such a strong emotional reaction?

Part of the answer is that Charlie Kirk was not just a political figure, but also a content creator. He had produced thousands of videos over many years, and millions of people had watched him, listened to him, and felt connected to him. Whether someone agreed with him or

not, his audience had built a real emotional connection with him by consuming so much of his content.

That is the point I want to emphasize. When people see videos of a person or organization over and over again, a kind of digital familiarity begins to form. They start to feel like they know the person. They start to like the person. They begin to trust the person.

Consistent videos and posts help people feel more familiar with the priest, the staff, the ministries, and the parish community. Over time, the parish starts feeling like a community they actually know well. And when people feel connected, they are far more likely to respond when the parish invites them to take a next step. Therefore, you want to continuously post videos on your platforms so viewers develop an emotional connection with the pastor, the staff, and the parish as a whole.

Way #2 – Stories and Going Live

Facebook and Instagram have two features that let people get warmed up to you very quickly: stories and going live.

Stories are a type of content that, after posting, disappears in 24 hours, unlike regular videos and posts. That means there's a "scarcity" element to them. People want to see your stories before they disappear. And since they're gone in a day, the content is typically what you (or the parish) is doing that day.

Seeing what someone does throughout the day warms people up quickly. Imagine seeing Father Mike Schmitz post about morning Mass, a workout, meetings, and a talk at a Newman Center. You would start to feel like you know him in a more personal way than if you only watched his polished videos.

Going live is similar. "Going live" refers to the feature on Facebook and Instagram that allows you to livestream yourself on camera to all

of your followers. People can join in and ask you questions and you can respond in real time. This is a fantastic tool to warm people up, because it's the next-best thing to talking with you in person. It cuts through all of the fancy editing and scripting that is part of creating videos, and it allows your audience to just see you authentically.

Step #3 – Convert (Ask)

It was June of 2023, and I was a month behind on rent. In 2022, I spent $30,000 for my first year of law school, pretty much all of my savings...but then I dropped out. To sell fitness online. To my friends and family, I looked like I had completely lost my marbles.

My plan was pretty simple. I would post fitness videos on social media. And then anyone that liked, followed, or commented, I would message and see if they wanted to buy my fitness program. I would send about 100 messages a day. It was rough...I was making about $2000/mo, which did not cover my monthly expenses.

And the worst part was that every time I finished sending all of the messages, I just felt desperate and salesy. Like I was chasing people who didn't want to be chased.

On top of all that, if I couldn't get this fixed in the near future, I'd have to get a job or go back to school, both of which sounded terrible.

One weekend in 2023, I went to a conference for fitness coaches. And there, through a mutual friend, I was introduced to a man named Cole da Silva. He had 500,000 followers on Instagram, and got rich off of social media. I didn't care about being rich, I just wanted to figure out this Instagram thing so I could pay my rent.

So when I had a second to talk with him one-on-one, I asked him my most pressing question.

"Hey real quick, when I DM people all the time, but so few people want to buy my stuff. I post all the time on social media. What am I doing wrong?"

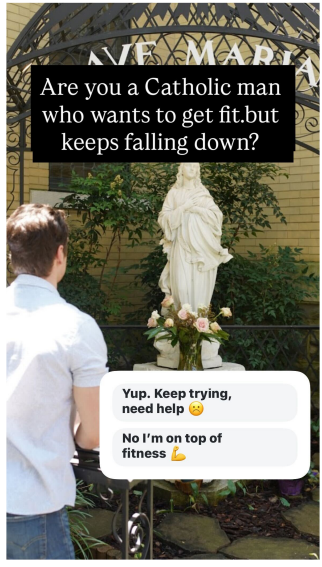
Cole asked me one question: “Are you messaging people who already responded to your stories?”

I told him no. I was just messaging people randomly.

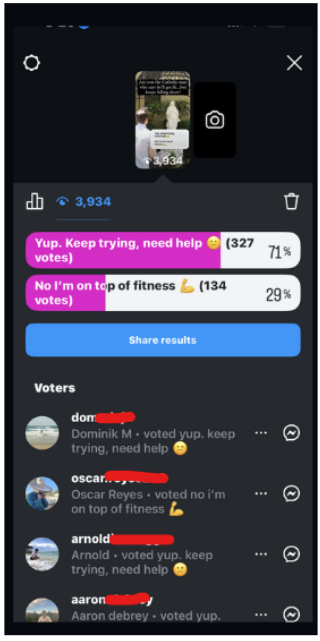
“That’s your problem,” he said. “Stories are where your warmest audience is. Ask there.”

Makes sense, I thought. I mean, things couldn't get much worse so I was willing to try anything. I thanked him, and when I got back from the conference, I told myself I would ask on my stories to see if anyone wanted to join my fitness program.

I didn't expect anyone to respond, but I posted it one night, and went to bed.



What happened next shocked me. I woke up to 327 Catholic men voting that they wanted fitness help.



I screenshotted it immediately, out of shock. Cole was right! I started messaging all of them. I was so excited. Not because of the money. But because I finally started seeing results.

I didn't have to chase random people anymore. I could simply DM the people who already said they were interested.

That's when it clicked: I should ask wherever the highest concentration of my nurtured audience already was. For me, that was Instagram stories. So I made my ask there. Those 327 responses turned into 20 booked calls, and I closed the majority of them. It became the highest revenue month I had ever had.

But more importantly, I finally found a way to ask people without feeling pushy, salesy, or desperate. And I finally felt like I was doing things the right way.

3 Parts To An Ask

The secret to asking is to make sure you ask **wherever there is the highest concentration of your nurtured audience**. For me at the time, that was on my Instagram stories. If you run paid advertising (which I recommend in the later chapters), it will likely be in the advertisements. I developed a strategy for asking your audience regardless of where you ask. Every time you ask your audience to do something, there should always be three main parts you include.

1. The callout
2. The value
3. A call to action

Let's go over each part.

Part #1 – The Callout

A callout is just that: you are *calling out* the people you're asking to do something. If you are asking St. John parishioners to volunteer as an usher for the 4pm Mass? Then literally say in the ask: "St. John Parishioners: Feel called to help welcome people to Mass?" Call out the people you are talking to.

Why? There's a saying in social media: people swipe the height of the Eiffel Tower every day. Think about that. You are competing with so many different posts, videos, stories, etc. You *need* to stop the scroll,

and the best way is to just call out that person. That way when they see the ask, they think, "Hey that's me. I'm a St. John parishioner." And they continue reading.

Part #2 – The Value

When I was visiting my brother in Colorado Springs one time, we were visiting over a weekend so Mikaella and I had to find a Mass on Sunday. We found a Latin Mass parish at 9:00AM, and decided to go since we don't have those in our parish, and that it would be cool to check out. But during the homily, things got frustrating. The pastor spent the entire homily discussing how the price of the votive candles are going up because "times are tough." He explained the process of how to buy the votive candles, and how long the candles last, and where to place the money. This went on for over 15 minutes. After mass, I had a very negative and confused feeling towards donating to that church. Primarily because the pastor never explained *what the money is going towards*. So I had no emotional drive to make a donation. I ended up not donating, and now go to a different parish when visiting Colorado Springs.

If you're going to ask, always explain what it's for. For example, if you're asking people to give money, always talk about what can come of the donations, because that is what gets people emotional. People may justify decisions with logic, but they are usually moved to act by emotion. That is why, when you ask for money, volunteers, or attendance, you need to explain why the ask matters.

The value is the part of the ask that explains the thing you're wanting people to attend or do, so they are emotionally motivated to do it. If it's attending a young adult event, this is where you explain what the event is and why it's so much fun. If it's donating, this is where

you explain what amazing project the money is going towards. It's always a good idea to make this section a bit story-esque or emotional, if possible, because that's what makes people do things. Think of this section as "the sell." People are busy. They have things going on. Why on earth should they come to a bake sale, or a young adult event, or a newlywed night? This is where you convince them.

Part #3 – Call to Action

Before I moved to California in 2025, I lived most of my life in Wisconsin. Back in my midwest parish, they hosted an amazing young adult event one night. Guys showed up and smoked cigars. Girls showed and brought baked goods. The vocations director gave a talk for men and women discerning. It went on for hours and was a blast.

Or so I was told.

Being a recent convert, I wasn't in the group chats and the inner circles quite yet. And the parish never advertised for the event. All I saw was a post about it in the bulletin saying "Young Adult Night coming soon, but no way to reserve a spot or contact someone. So because of that, I never showed up.

You *always* want a simple way for the person to comply with the ask, right then and there. That's called the Call to Action (CTA).

This is where you tell them exactly what it is you want them to do. "Click to register..." "Tap here to..." "Subscribe here...." The key with a CTA is to make them very, *very*, simple and with little to no friction. If you want them to apply to reserve an hour of Eucharistic Adoration, they just have to tap the link, tap their preferred time, and have their name Auto-filled from their iPhone keyboard. Low friction, low effort.

We've all seen posters in the church bulletin that say "register for X..." and to register, there's a long url on the poster they want us to type in to register. Most people won't do that (too much friction). If the poster had a QR code instead, there would be less friction and more people would respond.

This is essentially the basic social media system every parish needs to understand: you reach people, nurture people, and then ask them to take a meaningful next step. Reach gets people into your parish bubble. Nurture helps them know, like, and trust the parish. Conversion happens when you make a clear ask to the people who have already been nurtured. Therefore, a parish should not just post content to "stay active" online. It should post with a purpose, which is to close the attention gap, build goodwill, and invite people into deeper participation in parish life. Whether the goal is Mass attendance, event registration, volunteering, giving, or simply helping people feel more connected to the parish, the process is the same. Reach them, nurture them, and then make the ask clear, simple, and easy to follow.

Key Takeaways

- Social media is a giant funnel with three parts: reach, nurture, and convert
- Parishes can reach people with local follower ads and posting reels
- Parishes can nurture their audience with content, stories, and going live
- Parishes should ask their audience in the place where there is the highest concentration of their nurtured audience

- Asks always have three parts: the callout, the value, and the CTA

Section II: Organic Content

Chapter Four

H.A.C.S. Framework

By early 2026, I had a stable client base of Catholic parishes I was helping. The good news was that I had clients. The bad news was that the work was taking up all of my time. I was treating each parish as a custom project, posting what they wanted to post, tailoring campaigns to what they preferred. There was really no method to the madness, and I felt overwhelmed and exhausted. And I was not able to give a clear answer to the question every parish eventually asks: “What are we supposed to post?”

As it happened, I was reading a book at that time called "Expert Secrets" by a marketing guru named Russell Brunson. In there he was explaining how to give a webinar online. What was interesting however, was how simple and straightforward he made it. He boiled it down to four steps, and said that as long as a person were to follow this framework for presenting webinars, they would always have a successful webinar. He even explained how he designed the framework he taught in the book.

I mulled that last point over. That's what I wanted to do for parishes: design a simple framework that if they implemented, they would all see results. If they had that, both the parishes and I could finally have a structured work routine and get more peace of mind. So I got to work.

After several iterations, I landed on a simple four-part framework any Catholic parish can follow to post with intention and increase engagement. I call it the H.A.C.S. Framework:

H – Homily Clips

A – Activity Posts

C – Connection Posts

S – Stories (for Asks)

I started implementing it with my parish clients, and the results were immediate. I finally found a repeatable system I could implement in parish after parish to get people engaged and grow the ministry.

Each part of the framework has a specific job. Homily clips give value. Activity posts show social proof. Connection posts build familiarity. Stories allow the parish to make Asks. Together, these four content types help a parish reach people, nurture them, and invite them to take a meaningful next step. So with that, let's break down the H.A.C.S. Framework, step-by-step.

H – Homily Clips

"H" stands for homily clips. Homily clips are short videos taken from the Sunday homily and posted as reels on Facebook and Instagram.

This content does two important things at once. First, because it is posted as a reel, it can reach new people. Second, because it gives spiritual insight, encouragement, or practical advice, it nurtures the audience by giving value.

In the Know/Like/Trust framework, homily clips help people *like* the parish because the parish is helping them. A good 30–60 second homily clip can encourage someone, challenge them, teach them something, or give them a reason to think about God in the middle of the week.

A – Activity Posts

Activity posts show parish life in action, like a group photo from a parish event. This type of content is still "giving" to the audience, it's just not giving helpful advice to solve problems (aka it's not giving value).

But that's ok. It's still a valuable piece in nurturing the audience, because it shows visible proof that parish life is active, joyful, and worth participating in. They see the parish hosted an event, people showed up to the event, and they had a good enough time to get together for a group photo and smile. Subconsciously, that makes people think things like "the parish has good events" or "they know what they're doing."

Here are a few examples of activity posts that your parishioners would like to see.

- Group photos from young adult events
- Photos from RCIA or OCIA
- Choir rehearsal photos

- A photo of the pastor in front of church renovations
- A group photo of the parish team
- Nuptial Mass photos from parishioners
- A priest blessing a newborn
- Photos from First Communion
- Behind-the-scenes photos of catechists teaching

You might believe people already trust the parish, and they probably do to a point. But I don't mean trust you in the sense of feeling safe or something. I mean they have positive reinforcement that engaging at the parish by attending events, volunteering, or giving, is joyful. And this comes from them constantly seeing the results of people in their community attending events, volunteering, and giving. That's what the activity posts are for.

If a 20-something-year-old parishioner sees five posts from a young adult event where people are having fun, he will instinctively think, "If I go, I will have fun." That's what we want.

What is Social Proof?

Social proof is the idea that people are more likely to do something when they see other people doing it. We use social proof constantly. When we buy something on Amazon, we look at reviews. When we choose a restaurant, we notice whether it is full or empty. When a friend recommends a dentist, we trust the recommendation more than a random advertisement.

Parish life works the same way. If parishioners constantly see photos of people attending events, volunteering, joining ministries, receiving sacraments, and enjoying parish life, they begin to see participation as normal. They think, "People like me are involved here. Maybe I should be too."

That is the purpose of activity posts. They show parishioners that parish life is alive and the things going on around the parish are worth attending.

C – Connection Posts

Connection posts are story-based posts that help people feel familiar with the parish. They help parishioners get to know the priest, the staff, the history, the ministries, and the mission of the parish.

Examples of connection posts include:

- Why the pastor became a priest
- The history of the parish
- A recap of the past year
- The story behind a parish ministry
- A profile of a seminarian from the parish
- A parishioner testimony
- A staff member introduction
- The pastor's vision for the parish

"Hold on," you might be thinking. "I'm trying to get people to receive more sacraments, and be more engaged at the parish. Why do

I need to tell them stories?" Let me shed some light on this concept by sharing a story from when I was a teenager (see what I did there).

The Power of Familiarity

When I was 16, I almost joined a pyramid scheme called Verve. My friend Josh told me one day in high school that he was invited to a friend's house, and that friend told him to bring any of Josh's other friends. So he brought me.

These kids were a year ahead of us, and they were "pretty cool" by high school standards. When we arrived, we walked around back and opened the screen door, there were about 12 kids hanging out in the living room. And they were all friendly and welcoming, not something I expected from 12 Juniors when two Sophomores walked in.

"Josh!" one of them exclaimed. "So glad you could make it. And who's your friend?"

"I'm Joey," I said. "Nice to meet you."

"I'm Ryan," that kid said. This is where I live. Super excited you could make it bro." The kids handed us energy drinks from a company called Verve, and we hung out for a while listening to music and playing video games. Eventually, Ryan turned the music off and asked Josh, me, and a couple others to sit on the couch because he had something to tell us.

"Ok, obviously I love hanging out with you guys...but there's actually something really cool I wanted to share with you guys too."

I looked to Josh, not really sure what was going on.

"We have a business opportunity for you guys, where you can make a ton of money..."

I'll spare you the rest of the talk (for both our sakes), but suffice it to say, 16-year-old Josh was bought in hook, line, and sinker. He was

ready to make the first "investment into himself" for $800, which came with 20 cases of Verve energy drinks.

Now here's where things got interesting. Josh had been my best friend for years, and we did everything together. He was like a brother to me. So seeing him get so excited made *me* get excited and want to do it. And so *I was bought in too*. I was persuaded not mainly by Ryan, but by Josh, because Josh was my friend.

"We're in," Josh said. "How do we join?"

"Sweet! So it's just an $800 investment to get started," Ryan said.

I didn't have $800, so I told them I'll have to ask my parents for the money. Josh said the same.

On the drive home, Josh and I talked about the sports cars we were going to drive, and how he finally found a way out of going to college.

Josh dropped me off, and I went inside to talk with my mom and dad. Long story short, they saw it was clearly a pyramid scheme and shot me down (same with Josh's parents), and I hated them for ruining my hopes and dreams.

Looking back, what's fascinating is how susceptible I was not necessarily by Ryan's pitch, but by *Josh's excitement.* My actions were strongly persuaded by Josh, because he was my friend. When it comes to persuasion, there's few things more powerful than familiarity and friendship. In other words, Josh was persuaded by Ryan, and I by Josh, due to the Rule of Familiarity.

The Rule of Familiarity is this: people are more likely to say yes to someone they know and like. This matters for parish social media because many parishioners do not feel personally familiar with the priest, staff, ministries, or mission of the parish. Connection posts solve that problem.

Stories Build Up Familiarity

Ryan understood this rule, but he unfortunately had some ulterior motives. We don't have to follow in his footsteps. We can use this rule for more virtuous purposes: bringing people to the sacraments.

When we make posts that tell a story and invite an emotional response, we are making the viewer familiar with us. Imagine if a parishioner knew, why the pastor became a priest, what the pastor's vision is for the parish, the pastor's favorite restaurant in town is, and how he likes to spend his days off. Wouldn't that same parishioner be more likely to say yes to a request (e.g., attend an event, donate, etc.) from the priest in the future? Of course.

When your mom's friend asks her to come to a Tupperware party, won't she go? Won't she go and buy at least one thing from her friend? The warmth, the security, and the obligation of friendship are brought to bear.

That is the foundation behind the Rule of Familiarity, and why it is a powerful tool for a parish to make the parishioners familiar with the parish.

And the way we do so, is with connection posts.

S – Stories (for Asks)

"S" stands for Stories, specifically Facebook and Instagram Stories. This is where the parish can make the Asks. Stories are not the only place a parish can ask (they can also ask in paid ads, which I explain later in the book), but they are one of the best organic places to do it because the people watching your Stories are usually among your warmest audience members.

If we think back to what we've learned about asking, there are two guiding principles we need to follow when it comes to asking:

- Don't ask too much in a row and frustrate your audience

(Ch. 1)

- Ask where there is the highest concentration of nurtured audience members, so you're not wasting goodwill (Ch. 3)

Since you're following the H.A.C.S. framework, you don't have to worry about asking too much, because the homily clips, activity posts, and connection posts are giving enough to the audience to keep the goodwill high.

We *do* want to be cautious of asking efficiently though, because if we're not asking in the right places, we won't get people to do things, no matter how good our content is.

Stories or Ads?

To be clear, you can do all of your asking organically by posting on your Facebook and Instagram stories, and that's what I talk about in this book. It's 100% free, and it works. But you can also run paid advertisements around the parish to ask your audience. I have ran lots of paid ads for parishes and they work really well and *I strongly recommend* that strategy for asking, as I'll detail in Section III. But if money is tight at the parish, you can do all your asking for free on your Stories.

Posting Schedule

Now you know what to post on social media. But how *often* should you post?

I wouldn't overcomplicate it. For the "giving" content—the homily clips, activity posts, and connection posts—post one of each per week. That's three organic posts per week, well within the frequency of what

an active parish Facebook page should be posting. If you're a very large parish (like 15,000 families or more), post more often. But by that point, you probably have the resources to hire a full-time social media person, so it won't be that bad.

A simple weekly rhythm could look like this:

- Monday: Homily clip
- Wednesday: Activity post
- Friday: Connection post
- Saturday: An event invitation on your story

That gives the parish three strong posts per week without needing to become a full-time content machine.

You might have heard the rule of "post once per day" in the social media world. And yes, if you want to post once per day, it certainly won't hurt. But the parish is not trying to be a content creator or influencer. You just want to nurture your audience appropriately, with the limited resources you have at the parish.

Overall, this is a simple organic posting system that every parish can follow. Homily clips give value. Activity posts build trust. Connection posts build familiarity. All three nurture the audience and help them know, like, and trust the parish. Finally, stories create opportunities to invite people to take action. If your parish follows this rhythm consistently, your social media will become a stable and effective tool for engagement.

Key Takeaways

- Parishes can follow a simple posting system called the H.A.

C.S. Framework.

- H stands for Homily Clips, which give value and help people like the parish.
- A stands for Activity Posts, which show social proof that parish life is active, joyful, and worth joining.
- C stands for Connection Posts, which build familiarity and help parishioners get to know the parish.
- S stands for Stories, where parishes can make Asks.

Chapter Five

Giving Even More

We learned in Chapter 1 the importance of giving, so let's recap the main ways we have learned to give via social media:

- Homily clips
- Activity posts
- Connection posts

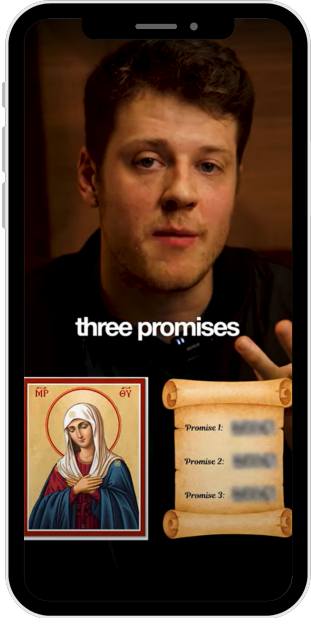
To clarify, the activity posts and the connection posts do "give," to be sure, but we post those more so to nurture the audience (to get them to warm up to us), as opposed to solving a problem for them. Primarily, it is the homily clips that are giving value to the audience, because those are the pieces of content that are generally solving problems for people. It's important to share content that makes people get to know you a bit more—like connection posts—and to see the activities around the parish—like activity posts—because that develops the connection they have towards the parish. But to really trigger the Rule of Reciprocity and get them to engage, we have to give something of value to them first.

So as of right now, the main way you have been doing that is through the homily clips. But what if you could keep posting connection posts and activity posts, but also multiply the amount of content that helps solve people's problems? Well, you would see significantly more positive responses when you ask for things in the future like attendance, donations, and volunteering.

So without further ado, if we want to give more, we turn to a 5th type of content: the talking-head reel.

The 5th Type of Content: Talking-Head Reels

A talking-head reel is simple to understand: it's a video where the person is talking directly to the camera.



Generally in a talking-head reel, the person's head is in the top-third of the screen, captions are below the chin, and any edits/graphics are in the bottom-third of the screen. You've probably seen hundreds of videos like this on social media, and that's because they're effective. And they're effective because it allows you to script exactly what you want to say to the camera before you post.

You can use talking-head videos with the sole intention of giving value by solving a problem for your audience. Rather than hoping to find a valuable nugget from a homily and clipping a 30-second chunk, you can now tailor the exact script to help someone. You can make an exciting hook to grab their attention and lay out the steps to solve their problem in a way that's easy to understand.

Scripting a Talking-Head Reel

The unique thing about talking-head reels is that they are scripted. There is a lot of data behind what makes people watch a short-form video, and what keeps their attention throughout the video. We can use this information to create a video that reaches and holds the attention of more viewers. So let's discuss how to script a talking-head reel.

The person speaking on camera (ideally the pastor or a parochial vicar) can follow the basic scripting structure of: (1) hook, (2) interest pique, (3) value, and (4) call to action.

The Hook

The hook is the first sentence of the video. We need to have a strong hook, or people will scroll away. David Ogilvy, the father of advertising, once said that when you have written your headline, you have

spent eighty cents of your dollar. The hook in our video is like the headline. It is by far the most important part of the video, because if the person doesn't like the hook and they scroll away, they never consume the value that is presented later in the video.

An important point is that a hook for an organic post—or content that was free to post—is different than the hook for an ad. The purpose of the hook for an ad is to call out the right audience member, like we discussed in Chapter 3. As you may remember, this is because we're trying to get someone to do something, so we're "calling them out" so to speak, so they take action. But the purpose of the hook for an organic post is to simply stop the scroll. This is because organic posts are not targeted like ads and may be shown to many different kinds of people, so we're not asking them to sign up or register or do anything like that. We simply want them to watch and consume. So the thought is, "how do I get people to stop scrolling?" rather than "how do I call out this specific type of person?"

When it comes to hooks for organic posts, here are a few rules to follow:

- Keep it short and sweet: 5-10 words is sufficient
- Try to invoke emotion with the words
- Include a "visual hook" on screen (like an image or graphic that represents the purpose of the video and grabs the viewers attention visually)
- Use 7th grade English or below (some estimates suggest that the average American reads at a 7th grade reading level and 20% of Americans are considered functionally illiterate)
- Negative performs better than positive ("Stop doing ABC..."

is a better hook than "Try doing XYZ...")

- Always wear your roman collar when the video starts (it signals authority immediately)

Because the hook is so important, try to spend the majority of your time on the hook. Remember, if you don't nail the hook, most people will never see the video.

Interest Pique

The interest pique is typically the second sentence of the video, and it's made to increase the viewers curiosity. First we grabbed their attention with the hook, now we pique their curiosity even more so they watch the whole video. Here's a simple example:

Hook: Here are 3 tips to make a better confession
Interest Pique: And #3 is the most important
...

Now the viewer is more likely to stay because they want to see the most important tip for giving a good confession, which we strategically placed at the end of the video. They might have scrolled away before finishing the video if they never heard that interest pique.

As a side note, the interest pique is an important piece of scripting, but it's not the end of the world if you don't include it. Every video won't include all 4 pieces. Some might only have 3, some might have all 4. Some might include the call to action earlier in the video. It all depends, but here I'm outlining the basic structure.

Here are a few examples of interest piques:

- And this works even if _____
- Now I'm not saying [take action], but [common belief] does

not [cause a desirable outcome]

- There are way too many people still [negative outcome] when this makes it so easy
- The first one is called ___
- This is one of the most effective [niche] hacks according to [authority figure in the same niche]
- The answer for this is ___
- But here's the thing... (after a generally accepted statement)
- This is something that's basically unheard of in the [niche] world
- And [solution] is way [positive adjective] than you think
- I've actually been using this for [time period] and it works every time
- The question is, ___

Value

Now we move on to the meat of the video: the value portion. To emphasize again, solutions to people's problems are going to be valuable to them. But not all solutions are created equal. You could give an excellent solution to somebody's problem, but if it's too complicated to implement, they won't do it, and therefore won't receive value from it. Therefore, there are a few rules to follow when giving solutions to people in videos on social media.

#1 - The Solution is Free

Try to think of a solution to their problem that doesn't cost anything. If they need to learn how to pray, don't route them to the Hallow app for $60/year. Because they probably won't do it, which means they won't solve their problem. Instead, route them to something maybe on the website, or in your online community. That's 100% free.

#2 - They Can Implement Within 24 Hours

People love having their problems solved quickly. When you're writing an email, or posting in your online community, consider providing a solution to a common problem that they can solve quickly—such as a prayer routine they can start tomorrow, or a discussion they can have tonight to improve a marital problem. Quick solutions are highly valued by people.

#3 - The Solution Is Easy to Understand

If they can't understand it, they won't be able to implement it. For example, one thing I always do when scripting content for social media is make sure all of the scripts are at a seventh-grade reading level. This is what the majority of Americans speak at, which means if I want the greatest number Americans to understand me, I need to give information in a way that they can understand.

#4 - They Can See Themselves Doing It

Sometimes people leave a homily, or scroll past a reel, and think "Sounds nice, but I couldn't do that." Making the solution general enough to where anyone can see themselves doing it, will instill motivation in them to actually implement.

I have used this value-video structure for years, and it has consistently worked well for me. People spend 30 seconds to watch a video that has a solution to a problem, that's free, quick, easy to understand, and easy to implement. Who wouldn't like that? If you look at my Instagram account, I have over 100,000 followers as of writing this. My content is, and has been for years, almost exclusively value videos, structured just like I explained above. It works.

CTA

Because we have given value to our audience, we have earned the opportunity to make a small ask. You can bank the goodwill for a future ask, or you can spend a little at the end of the video.

For organic videos, I always like to tie my CTA's to something that actually gives them even more value. That way, even though I'm asking, I'm spending goodwill to bank even *more* goodwill in the future. Here are a few examples:

- "Follow for more tips like this"
- Comment "Pray" and I'll send you a simple routine you can follow each day
- Save this video if you'd like to receive more helpful videos like this one

You don't need one, but if the video is valuable, people are more likely to respond to a clear next step. So I say take advantage of it, get creative, and guide people to the next step.

Pro-tip: I've actually seen great success putting an additional CTA somewhere in the middle of the video. For example, I once made a video about the 12-Year Prayer of St. Bridget.

This was the script:

> **Hook:** There's a Catholic prayer that if you pray it daily for 12 years, Jesus promises to defend you at Judgement
>
> **Interest Pique:** It's called the 12-Year Prayer of St. Bridget. Let's break it down
>
> **Value:** St. Bridget was a mystic in the 1300's who started receiving revelations about the Passion of Christ. In those revelations, Jesus gave her this prayer and the gifts that come from praying it for 12 years. Now I know you're wondering, so what's the prayer?
>
> **CTA:** Well, it takes 10 minutes, so comment "PRAY" below and I'll send it to you.

Value: Now what's fascinating are the gifts that Jesus said would come from doing this. You will suffer no purgatory...(list the other promises traditionally associated with the devotion, though private revelations)... Fascinating, and worth looking into.

CTA: Again if you want the prayer, comment "PRAY" and I'll send it over.

In that video, I included the CTA to receive the prayer halfway through. It saw tremendous results. The video received over 50,000 comments asking for the prayer, on just one platform (Instagram).

Again, the original order is just a guideline, and sometimes moving the parts around can yield better results.

Putting it All Together

As you can probably tell, there's a lot of strategies going on behind the scenes of these videos. That's why we script them, to make sure:

- the hook is engaging,
- the solution is free, easy to understand, quick to implement, and something viewers can see themselves doing, and
- the CTA is straightforward.

Here's an example:

> **Hook:** Here's 3 tips on how to make a great confession.
>
> **Interest Pique:** And number 3 is most important
>
> **Value:** First, always prepare before you enter the confessional by spending 5–10 minutes doing an examination of conscience. Second, be clear and direct. Mention the sin, and the number of times committed, and that's sufficient; no need to tell a long story. Finally, have the actual intention to change. Ask yourself, what concrete steps will I take this week to change?

CTA: Save this if you'd like more helpful videos like this one

Post on all Social Media Platforms

Large creators understand a simple principle: once you make a strong piece of content, you should distribute it as widely as possible. A video that performs poorly on Instagram might do well on Facebook. A clip that gets ignored on Facebook might find the right audience on YouTube Shorts or TikTok.

Parishes should think the same way. If you already created a talking-head reel, do not post it in only one place. Post it on Facebook, Instagram, YouTube Shorts, TikTok, and, if appropriate, X. Each platform gives the content another chance to reach someone, give value, and nurture the audience.

So, we want to post on all major social media platforms:

1. Facebook
2. Instagram
3. X (formerly Twitter)
4. YouTube Shorts
5. TikTok

Each platform has a slightly different algorithm for sending content to viewers. Therefore posting on all platforms just gives more at-bats to go viral, and more at-bats to nurture your parishioners. Some parish-

ioners are on Facebook and X, some are only on Instagram, and some are only on TikTok. Posting on all five major platforms covers all bases.

Bottom Line

At the end of the day, it is volume that matters. Compare the following scenarios:

Scenario 1: Parish A posts 2-3 times a week on Facebook. After one month, they have made 10 pieces of content in total.

Scenario 2: Parish B posts 7 days a week, on all five platforms. After one month, they have made 140 pieces of content.

A 14x delta. That is a massive difference. More content gives your parish more opportunities to reach people, give value, and nurture the audience. It does not guarantee virality, but it increases your number of chances.

Again, the H.A.C.S. Framework is the baseline. If your parish can post one homily clip, one activity post, and one connection post per week, you are already ahead of most parishes. But if you want to increase reach and give even more value, the next step is to add talking-head reels.

Key Takeaways

- We can give more to our audience by making more videos that solve problems for people.
- A great strategy for this is talking-head reels that were scripted beforehand.
- Talking-head reels can follow a basic structure of hook, interest pique, value, and CTA.

- Another technique to give more is to post videos on all social platforms, not just Facebook and Instagram.

Chapter Six

Asking More Efficiently

I still remember the night this finally clicked for me.

I was at my parish in California in 2025, and a Dominican friar was coming in to give a talk at the parish. He seemed very sharp, and I was excited to hear from him. I only found out about the event because one of the parish priests mentioned it to me and I saw a blurb about it in the bulletin. At the time, promotion through social media was an afterthought, and email and texting were not being used in a systematic way.

Honestly, I still expected a good crowd. It's a big parish and it's not every day you get to hear from a Dominican friar. So I showed up a little early, grabbed a seat, and waited.

Five minutes before the start time, the room was almost empty. A couple of older parishioners sat in the front row. One family slipped in and took a seat in the back. By the time the friar stood up to begin, there were maybe a 15-20 of us in the room.

Sitting there, I felt a mix of embarrassment and frustration. I didn't think that the people didn't care about coming to these things, because this was *exactly* the type of event I wanted to come to. And it wasn't that the parish hadn't said anything. They had. They put it in the "right place," the bulletin, in front of the "right people," their own parishioners.

And it still didn't work.

Driving home that night, the question kept bugging me: "If we asked the right people, in the right spot, why didn't they come?"

And I came to this realization: it's not enough to *ask* the right people in the right place. The *Ask* itself has to be compelling. It has to be strong enough that a normal, busy person will actually change their plans and show up.

Most parishes think they have an "awareness problem." They assume, "If people just knew about this, they'd come." But that night I realized that it can also be an a*sk* problem. The way we invite people to events, ministries, and sacraments can be weak and generic, and therefore very easy to ignore.

After that, I started looking at everything differently: flyers, announcements, emails, social posts. I kept asking myself, "Do these things motivate me to actually take the next step?" And most of the time the honest answer was no.

Out of that frustration came a simple idea: you can dramatically increase how many people respond if you consistently do three things with every ask you make, whether it's in a bulletin or on social media. In other words, a strong Ask does three things:

- You professionalize the creative.
- You choose the right call to action.
- You include some real scarcity.

When you do those three things, your Asks become more efficient. And that's better for the parish, because your efforts get more positive responses. And it's better for your parishioners, because they finally see and respond to the things that can actually help them grow in faith.

In the rest of this chapter, I'm going to show you exactly how to do that on social media for your Catholic parish.

Principle #1 – Professionalize the Creative

When I first started helping parishes with social media, it was common for me to take a flyer from the bulletin and post it directly to Facebook or Instagram Stories. It rarely worked well.

The problem is that a bulletin flyer and a FB/IG Story are not the same thing. A bulletin flyer is usually viewed by someone already holding the bulletin in their hands. A Story is viewed by someone tapping through content quickly while distracted. That means the design has to be simpler and much more direct.

The L.E.C.T.I.O. Framework gives a helpful guide on how to design every ask for social media before posting, so it's simple and direct. In fact, before any ask is made on social media, the person who designed the ask can always reference this framework to make sure it's the best it can be. As a side note, a lot of these aspects translate to the bulletin flyers as well.

Here is the L.E.C.T.I.O. Framework:

L – Large Callout

E – Emojis

C – Contrast

T – Touch of Art

I – Info Snapshot

O – Obvious CTA

Below I lay out each step in detail.

L – Large Callout

The headline / callout is the very first thing people see or hear in your Ask that makes them think, "This is for me, I should pay attention." It's the short line that grabs your ideal person out of the noisy room of social media and labels them, their problem, or their dream outcome. And its only job is to sell the next second of attention. If they never notice or identify with that line, nothing else in the ad matters.

In practice, the headline/callout is the big, obvious text (or opening words) on the story that both 1) gets their attention and 2) implies there's value if they keep watching/reading.

So not only does the callout need to get their attention and imply that there's value if they keep reading, it also has to be BIG. So they see it immediately. A good rule to make sure it's big enough is the following: when writing the headline, place your screen at arms length. If you can't read the headline in half a second, it's too small. This will ensure that the headline is large enough to stop the scroll and grab the viewer's attention.

E – Emojis

Emojis are graphic symbols you can generate that convey information without words. This is helpful, because it allows you to save space on the design. For example, instead of saying "Phone Number: 555..." you can simply place the phone emoji and write the number next to it, saving 11 characters of space.

The other benefit is that since there is less text for people to read, they comprehend it quicker. And the more people that understand quicker before scrolling away, the greater the number of positive re-

sponses to the ask. But restraint is important too. Emojis should clarify information, not make the design feel childish or cluttered.

C – Contrast

Contrast means there is a big color difference between the background and the copy (or words on the page). Because people are scrolling so quickly, when they do land on our Story and begin viewing, we don't want any obstacles—like difficulty reading—getting in the way.

Having a dark background with white text, or a white background with dark text, is always a safe bet.

Here is an example of a flyer for a single women's event with low contrast. It's slightly difficult to read because both the background and copy are shades of brown.

And here is the social media Ask for the Story, with high contrast.

White background and dark text is always a safe bet. In fact, I only generate flyers for bulletins/social media that have white/cream/off-white backgrounds and dark text, unless requested by the parish.

T – Touch of Art

The "Art" in your Story ad is everything visual that is **not** the message: backgrounds, textures, photos, icons, flourishes, fancy fonts. **Its**

job is simply to make the message easier to notice and feel, not compete with it.

Oftentimes churches will cover a flyer in art, and basically turn the whole thing into wallpaper. When this happens, the eye doesn't know where to land, so people skim, feel "busy," and leave. In ads, attention is a finite resource: every extra dove, stained glass overlay, or script font is stealing attention from the hook, the benefit, or the next step.

Therefore, the rule I'd give a church team is: "If a design element doesn't make the headline more obvious or the call to action more obvious, delete it." Ads are not bulletin murals; they're billboards that people see for half a second. Clear beats pretty, clear beats clever, and clear definitely beats clutter.

I – Info Snapshot

The **"info snapshot"** is the tiny section of your flyer or Story ad that answers the basic event questions **without stealing the show** from the callout, value, and CTA. Its only job is to quickly confirm: *what it is, when it is, where it is,* and maybe *one key detail* (like childcare). Think of it like the nutrition label, not the whole meal.

Practically, that means grouping the details into a small box or cluster with **3–5 short lines max**: Event name, date, time, location, and one special note if needed. No paragraphs, no full schedules, no mini-sermon. The callout grabs attention, the value line makes them care, the CTA tells them what to do, and the info snapshot quietly fills in the logistics. If your info block starts competing for attention with the headline or CTA, it's too big and you're crowding the ad.

O – Obvious CTA

The CTA has to be obvious because people are busy and distracted, and they will not stop to figure out what you want them to do. If the

headline sells attention, the CTA sells the action. When a church flyer or Story ad has a nice message but a vague or hidden next step, you've basically inspired people and then left them in the parking lot with no directions. "Learn more," five different links, or tiny text in a corner all create friction and confusion.

You want one clear command, in plain language, in a big, obvious place: "Scan to RSVP," "Tap to Plan Your Visit," "Sign Up for Baptism." Your job is to remove thinking. The more the viewer has to interpret, zoom, or decide between options, the more likely they are to do nothing. An obvious CTA means more people are actually taking the next step with the parish.

Principle #2 – Choose the Right CTA For the Ask

One time a parish asked me for help with getting ushers for the 4PM Saturday Mass. So I made a very nice looking post for their Facebook and Instagram Stories. It asked the parishioners if they want to be a welcoming face at Mass, it included all of the helpful details, and then at the bottom it said "click the link to learn more." That button led to a Google Form for the viewer to fill out. The idea was that after they filled out their information the parish staff could reach out to them afterwards.

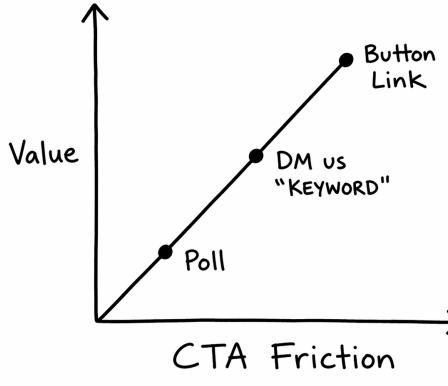
But that didn't happen. Over 700 parishioners viewed the Facebook and Instagram Stories...and not a single person signed up.

I *knew* the creative looked nice, and the copy I chose was effective. But it still didn't get signups. That's when I realized that if you don't have the right CTA attached to the ask, it will fall flat no matter how good the creative and copy are.

Once I understood that, I posted a similar ad on the story, but with an easier CTA (just vote on a poll if you're interested) and we started to actually get hands raised.

The Value-Friction Graph

I learned that the right call to action is tied to the value of the ask itself, and not all CTAs are used for the same ads. After posting dozens of different asks on the Stories for parishes, I came up with a framework for choosing the appropriate CTA that I call the Value-Friction Graph.



Here's how it works: people are willing to do more work if there is a lot of value in it for them. Similarly, people are *not* willing to do a lot of work when there is not a lot of value in it for them.

For example, let's say Bishop Robert Barron and Mark Wahlberg were in town and were going to grab beers with five people at your parish, just because. You saw this on the FB and IG Stories for the parish. To be one of the five, you had to drive over to the parish within

the next three hours and fill out a form. Now driving to the parish can be kind of a hassle. People have work, they got the kids, they're busy...but some people would do it! Because it's not every day you get to meet famous Catholics. In other words, they're willing to do something that's kind of a drag (friction) if the payoff is really worth it (value).

Let's look at an opposing example. Let's say the parish needed five people to help clean the sanctuary. The parish posts about it on the Facebook and Instagram Stories. To be one of the five, you had to drive over to the parish within the next three hours and fill out a form. Do you think people would do that? Probably not. Too much friction, too little value.

The solution, therefore, is to pair the amount of value in the ask with the amount of friction in the CTA. Below I go over three different types of Asks you will make on your Stories, and how to select the proper CTA for each.

High Value—>High Friction (Button Link)

If the thing you are asking people to do has a lot of perceived value, you can go direct with a button link. A link to the registration page for an event, a link to a Google Form, a link to a donation page, etc. This is the most ideal CTA for the parish, because it requires no additional work for the parish team. Simply make the ask on the Story, include a link to the registration page/form, and you're done.

These CTAs are great for things like guest speakers at the parish, pilgrimages, and things like that.

Medium Value—>Medium Friction (DM us "KEYWORD")

If the thing you are asking people to do has a medium amount of perceived value to them, a button link on the Story will be a bit

too much friction for them. Therefore, we want to go with a slightly "less-friction" CTA: direct messaging (DMing) the account a simple keyword.

This is pretty easy, since all they have to do is reply to the Story with a word. Once they do that a parish worker can pop into the inbox and have a quick conversation. Thank them for their interest, answer any questions they have, and guide them to the next step.

By reducing friction on the CTA, it adds a bit more work on the parish team, but it's necessary if there is less perceived value for the person.

This type of CTA is great for things like asking for volunteers, joining a Bible study, coming to a Men's event, etc.

Low Value—>Low Friction (Story Poll)

If the thing you are asking people to do does not have a lot of perceived value to them, even sending a DM can be a bit too much work. Therefore, we utilize a CTA called a Story poll. Story polls allow the viewer to simply "tap" on the screen to vote on a poll, an action that has almost no friction at all.

Once the viewer taps on the poll, you can go in and view who voted on the poll, and message them accordingly.

These are great for things like bringing goods for a food drive, cleaning the sanctuary, setting chairs/tables up for events, data entry, etc.

A key thing to notice is that the CTA is chosen not based on how impactful these things are to the Church, but how valuable things are *to the viewer* in that moment. Play to people's own self-interest (we live in a fallen world, what can I say), and you'll see significantly more positive responses.

Principle #3 – Include Scarcity

"The way to love anything is to realize it might be lost."
– G.K. Chesterton

Scarcity is the principle that opportunities feel more valuable when availability is limited. If there are only a few seats left, only a few days to register, or only one chance to attend, people perceive the opportunity as more valuable. This is why rare collectibles sell for enormous amounts of money. A Honus Wagner baseball card can sell for millions because only a small number still exist. The limited availability increases the perceived value.

Parish asks work the same way. If people know an opportunity is limited, they are more likely to pay attention and respond.

This principle affects humans deeply for a couple of reasons. First is the "decision shortcut" idea similar to when we discussed social proof in Chapter 4. We have a lot of decisions to make day-to-day, and so our brain thinks that if something is scarce and limited, it's generally more valuable and that we should acquire it. The second reason is that we *hate* losing freedoms, and when we have the opportunity to do or get something, and then that opportunity is taken away, we don't like that. And most people will rebel against that feeling.

Therefore, when you're asking people to do something, adding scarcity will make the viewer find the ask more valuable, which will increase the number of positive responses. There are two main tactics Catholic parishes can use scarcity when asking their audience for things on social media:

- Limited Availability

- Deadline

Let's break down each one.

Tactic #1 – Limited Availability

The idea of limited availability is that there are only so many spots available for people to reserve, register, attend, etc. As you can guess (and have probably seen in the world) there are unethical ways to use this tactic. An event coordinator could say "ONLY 2 SPOTS LEFT, grab your tickets now!" when in fact there are many spots left. Sales would increase, to be sure, but it was done unethically.

You can avoid these unethical situations by being honest about the availability. For example, let's say you are wanting to increase attendance for women's Bible study. You might think, "hey the more the merrier," which is true in a sense...but you probably couldn't host 1 million people at the Bible Study, right?

Right. So there *is* limited availability. Maybe it's around 50 or 100, who knows. But it exists, so saying "Please sign up promptly, there is limited availability" is 100% true and ethical. And saying that in your ask would increase the number of positive responses.

Here's the rule to follow: if you know the limited availability, say the number. If you don't, just say "limited availability."

Tactic #2 – Deadlines

The deadline tactic leverages the instances where the person has only a certain time period to complete something, or they can no longer do it.

There are several instances of this in parish life. Parishioners often can only register children for First Communion during a certain date

range, for example. Or setting up for the Easter Vigil has to be done by Saturday morning.

What we want to do is simply state the deadline in the Ask, that is sufficient to increase the value of the ask, and therefore increase the number of positive responses.

The Bottom Line

If we want to *ask better*—assuming we're already asking the right people and asking in the right place—there's really only two things we can do: make the thing seem more valuable to the person, or make it easier for them to raise their hand.

Choosing the proper CTA (Principle #2) makes it easier for them to raise their hand, and including scarcity (Principle #3) and professionalizing the creative (Principle #1) makes the thing seem more valuable.

Pro tip: These concepts work across all marketing systems, even the bulletin! Try adding scarcity in your next bulletin flyer to get more positive responses.

Key Takeaways

- There are several ways to *ask better* so that you get more positive responses to your ask from your audience
- Professionalizing the creative "stops the scroll" and gets more people to view the Ask.
    - An easy way to remember how to professionalize the creative is to follow the L.E.C.T.I.O. Framework.
- Choosing the proper CTA for the Ask makes it easier for the

person to raise their hand.

    - To know which CTA to choose, follow the Value-Friction Graph.

- Adding scarcity increases the perceived value for the person, which increases the number of positive responses.

Section III: Paid Content (Ads)

Chapter Seven

Why Paid Ads?

Up to this point, we have focused mostly on organic social media: the posts, reels, Stories, and asks a parish can make for free. Organic content matters because it is the primary way you give value to your audience to nurture them. But when it's time to ask, we want to ask as efficiently as possible so we don't waste goodwill. That is where paid ads come in.

The Power of Paid Ads for a Parish

In April 2026, I started helping St. Patrick's Church in South Hadley, Massachusetts. They had an older congregation, and the pastor wanted more engagement from young adults.

"More young adults, got it," I confirmed during the Zoom consultation. "How's the social media?"

"Eh, not great," said the pastor. "We have someone posting the livestreams of the Sunday Mass and some flyers, but that's about it. I know we need to do a better job at that."

Maybe, I thought. They had money for ad spend. I figured the best thing would be to get a young adult ministry going ASAP and build the organic social media as time goes on.

"Alright, here's what I suggest. We run a Meta ad campaign in a 10-mile radius of the parish asking for a 'young adult ambassador' who can start hosting young adult events. I would recommend $20/day for 5 days. I'll message the leads and see if they're a good fit, we should be able to get someone within a week."

Father wasn't fully convinced. "What do you mean?" he asked.

"Well, the parish Facebook page is pretty dead. So, we are going to have to pay for attention since we don't have it organically. Catholics in South Hadley are on social media, they just are not watching the parish's content yet. So, we're going to pay Meta to put the invitation in front of them."

He thought for a moment. "Ok, let's do it."

We ran with the strategy. I created the ad below and ran it to 21–35-year-olds within a 10-mile radius of St. Patrick's Church.

The results were great. I spent $20/day for 5 days. We got six applications. Of those six, three interviewed. And two were a good fit. Of those two, I picked one man to lead the young adult ministry. He had recently moved from another parish, was in his twenties, and had a deep desire to help grow the young adult ministry at whichever parish he moved to.

To put this into perspective, the parish had not had an organized young adult ministry for a long time. And for only $100 and one week of time, we found a qualified, passionate, young adult ministry leader, *despite* a dead Facebook page and no Instagram page for the parish.

That is the power of paid ads at a Catholic church.

What I'm *Not* Asking You to Do

Before we talk about paid ads, I want to be clear about what I am *not* recommending.

I am not asking you to "run ads for Catholicism." We are not putting "Hey, come get baptized!" on a billboard in town, or taking out TV ad space to tell people about Holy Mother Church. Not only would that feel like bad taste to a lot of people, but it also probably wouldn't work very well. As you know, Truth sells itself, and we are not trying to manipulate anyone into our faith with marketing tricks.

What I am asking you to do is use ads to put clear, *specific* invitations in front of the people who are most likely to need or want them right now.

Instead of "Hey come get baptized," think:

- "Local young adult event this Sunday. Click below to learn more."

- "Love to sing? Choir members needed for the 4pm Saturday Mass."
- "Parents: get your child registered for First Communion."

Those are targeted asks with concrete next steps that real people in your area would want to engage with. Paid ads simply let you tap them on the shoulder and say, "Hey this is for you, are you interested?"

In fact, it is not unlike what you post in the bulletin every week. You are spending money on printing and publishing to draw attention to events and volunteering positions at the parish. Same thing here, we are just using a different medium.

Why Paid Ads?

Prior to this chapter we have talked about organic social media: posts that are free to publish on Facebook and Instagram. But now we discuss another side to these platforms. It is the side that made Meta one of the most valuable companies in the world: paid advertising.

With an organic (free) post, Facebook shows your content to some of your followers and a few new people. The good news is that you can reach people for free. The bad news is that you don't control *which* people see it or when they see it. That can be a problem. Imagine you post about a young adult event, but most of the people who follow your parish page are over sixty. The post will still go out, but not mainly to the people you actually want to invite. You "used up" an ask and spent goodwill, but the ask was ignored.

So, what's the solution? Well, you make a deal with Meta. You say, "We have this post, and we want this specific kind of person to see it, even if they've never heard of our parish." Meta says, "Okay, but you'll have to pay." You say, "Deal." You hand Meta the money, and Meta lets

you control who sees your content. Instead of hoping the right people happen to see your post, you choose the age, location, and other details of who sees it, and Meta rents you their attention. You are no longer guessing who will see the message or hoping for the best; you decide in advance what type of person you want it to reach.

As a Catholic parish, you'll mostly use paid ads for Asking rather than Giving. Ads cost money, so if you pay to "give value" to people, the return on that money is usually poor for the marginal goodwill you gain. But paid ads are an extremely efficient way to ask because you can invite or request something from exactly the people most likely to respond. Let us illustrate this efficiency by comparing asking in paid ads with asking on Facebook & Instagram Stories.

With organic Stories, you *can* ask: "We need choir members," "We need volunteers," "We are raising money for X." And this works! The people already following you see it, and because you have been giving them value over time, the Rule of Reciprocity often kicks in and some will say yes. But there is a major downside to asking only through organic content: you cannot control who watches those Stories or sees those posts. If 100 parishioners view the story and see the choir ask and only 15 people care about music, the other 85 were still "asked." Over time, this can feel like you are asking everyone for everything, even when most of the requests don't apply to them, and that slowly wears down their goodwill.

With ads, you can aim the same ask at people who are much more likely to be interested in music, so you spend your money and your goodwill on people who might actually say yes, instead of spending it on everyone and just hoping the right people happen to be in the crowd.

So why paid ads for Catholic parishes? Because they let you trade a small amount of money to put the right ask in front of the right

people, instead of announcing the ask to everyone and slowly wearing out their goodwill. Organic asks, like Facebook or Instagram Stories, are more like announcements at the end of Mass. Everyone hears them whether it applies to them or not. But paid ads are more like handing a flyer to someone you already know would be a good fit for what the flyer is advertising.

How Paid Ads Actually Work

Alright this all sounds great, but how do paid ads on Facebook and Instagram actually work? Meta has a feature called Meta Ads Manager where you can give them your post (i.e., your ad), a small set of clear instructions, a credit card, and then its system does the heavy lifting and sends the ad to the people you chose.

At a basic level, you make four decisions:

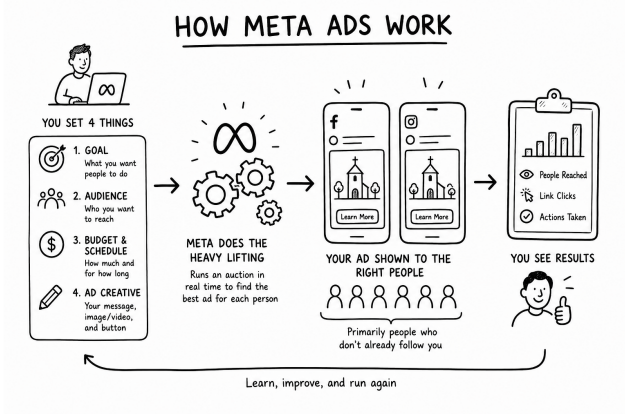
1. **Your goal.** You tell Meta what you want people to do: send a message, sign up for an event, visit your website, watch a video, or fill out a simple form. Think of this as your ask. Are you inviting people to a retreat? Asking them to register their kids for religious education? Asking lapsed parishioners to reconnect?

2. **Your audience.** You choose *who* you want seeing this invitation. You can narrow by location (e.g., people within 5–10 miles of the parish), age (e.g., 18–35 for young adult events), and sometimes interests (people interested in music for choir recruitment, etc.). The ad is no longer shouted at everyone. It is aimed at specific types of people who are more likely to care.

3. **Your budget and schedule.** You decide how much you are

willing to spend and for how long. This might be as simple as $10 a day for 10 days. Since budgets play an important role at parishes, Meta allows you to set a ceiling, and once the campaign hits that amount, it stops. The system will try to show your ad as many times as possible to the right people within that limit.

4. **Your copy and creative (the ad itself).** Finally, you create the ad: the picture or short video, the text above it, and the simple button like "Sign up," "Learn more," or "Send message." The ad is just a small, clear invitation that appears in the middle of someone's normal scrolling. If they are interested, they click and take the next step you have chosen.



After you do this, Meta begins working behind the scenes. Every time someone opens Facebook or Instagram, Meta runs a tiny auction to decide which ad to show in that person's feed at that moment. Many advertisers may want that same slot. Meta looks at who the user is, how well your audience settings match that person, how good your

ad is (do people usually respond to it), and how much you are willing to spend. Then it chooses the ad it believes will be the best fit for the viewer while still serving Meta's business interests. Now, you don't see any of this, but you do get to see results: how many people saw the ad, clicked it, and took the action you asked for.

So in practice, "running paid ads" is pretty straightforward. It is deciding: "What do we want people to do? Who do we want seeing this? How much can we invest? What simple invitation will we put in front of them?" Once those are in place, Meta delivers that invitation one-to-many, primarily to people who don't already follow your page, giving your parish a way to reach beyond the bulletin and into the phones of the exact neighbors you want to invite.

Do We Really Need These?

I spent the majority of the first half of the book talking about organic content. So you might be thinking, "Do we *really* need to spend money and run paid ads for a parish?" It's a fair question.

The Church has evangelized for 2,000 years without Facebook. So you can absolutely promote things at a parish using just the bulletin, mail, and email. Personally, I would say if your pews are full, your events are packed, your volunteer roster is overflowing, and your weekly giving is strong, you probably don't *need* ads.

But most parishes aren't there.

For a lot of parishes, they desperately need volunteers, events have the same 10 people, and they're just barely getting by financially. And this usually isn't because the parishioners don't care, but that they never really saw a clear invitation at the right time, with an easy way to raise their hand.

And speaking of people raising their hand, you can track this stuff! If you just post flyers in the bulletin, most parishes don't have a trackable system to see how well the flyers are doing, how interested people are, etc. Which means they post the flyer and hope for the best. In contrast, you can run an ad for an event, and you can track everyone that signs up for the event, and therefore *how much it costs, on average, to get an attendee for an event*. And with that, you can start planning ahead. I go into greater detail with this in the next chapter, but just knowing that you can have trackability is a key benefit.

You also don't have to spend a fortune. Think in terms of small, intentional experiments, not giant campaigns. For example, $10 a day for a local event for 7–10 days is $70–$100. Many parishes already spend that on flyers, or printing extra brochures. With ads, that same amount can put your invitation in front of hundreds or thousands of people who live within a few miles of the parish and actually fit the age or life situation you're trying to reach. You are simply trading a little bit of money for guaranteed reach to the right kind of people.

Now, will every ad be a home run? No. But a simple, imperfect campaign will often beat simply hoping people notice the bulletin announcement. Especially when the parish social media pages are small or inactive, organic social media reach alone won't be enough to make an impactful difference.

So, do you *need* paid ads? If you have a small organic social media presence, I would say yes. And even if you do, running paid ads allows you to ask more efficiently than asking organically (i.e., via Stories). As with many things, the answer is not one or the other, but both simultaneously. Give lots of value through organic content, and use ads to make targeted asks.

Key Takeaways

- Paid ads allow us to trade a small amount of money to put the right ask in front of the right people at the right time.
- Paid ads work by giving Meta instructions about your goal, audience, budget, schedule, and creative. Meta then delivers the ad to the people you chose.
- You don’t need to run paid ads, but they are an efficient way to ask, especially if you don't have a thriving organic social media presence.

Chapter Eight

3 Types of Ads for Parishes

When I first started jumping on Zoom calls with pastors, I figured every parish was completely different, and needed their own unique solutions to their problems. I figured the towns were different, and there's different cultures of people...But it turned out after about a dozen calls, the same three problems kept coming up:

"Can you help us get more people to show up for things?"

"Can you help us get more volunteers?"

"Can you help us reach more young adults?"

They wanted help with event attendance, volunteers, engaging young adults, or some combination of those.

And so I started to develop a bit of a routine. There were certain events that almost all parishes celebrated (Corpus Christi Procession, Patronal Feast Day, Paschal Triduum, etc.), and there were certain volunteering roles that almost all parishes needed (e.g., altar servers, catechists, young adult leaders, etc.). So I got in a flow of running similar advertising campaigns for multiple churches.

And after each campaign, I would learn this thing or that thing. Make this little tweak, or avoid doing this thing again. After dozens and dozens of campaigns, I got it down to a science. **There are three main campaigns every parish needs to run, and there is a specific way to run each of them that is proven to work.**

Now, when a new parish signs on with my company, I already know what event campaigns they probably want to run during the liturgical year, and what volunteer needs they probably have. And I almost have the entire annual marketing strategy planned by the time we shake hands. Not only does this give the parish leaders tremendous peace of mind, but also it makes the campaigns more successful since they're tried and true.

The 3 Parish Ads

Realistically, there are only really three types of ads for parishes to run:

1. Event Ads
2. Volunteer Ads
3. "First Mass" Outreach Ads

These three ad types correspond to the three basic movements of parish engagement: show up, serve, and worship. Event ads help people show up. Volunteer ads help people serve. First Mass ads help people cross the threshold into parish life. Together, they give a parish a simple paid advertising system focused on real engagement, not vanity metrics.

The first two often work well with people who already have some connection to the parish, though they can also be used to reach new local people. The "First Mass" ad is a bit unique, and designed to reach

people *not within our audience.* This is because if we want new people coming to our church, we can't just ask people already within the parish bubble, because they're already part of the parish! We have to go beyond the bubble. And ads let us do that.

Before we jump into the "First Mass" ads, let's break down two standard ads to run to your nurtured audience: volunteer ads and event ads.

Event Ads

These ads invite people to a concrete event, like a Corpus Christi Eucharistic Procession, the Easter Vigil, youth night, a seminar, a talk from a guest, and so on. People who want to attend events that see the ad only want one thing: they want it on their calendar so they have all the details, get reminders and don't forget about it. That makes sense, right? Someone asks if you want to attend something, and you do, you don't want to have to remember the date and time. You'd rather have it on your calendar, with all of the details included and you get reminders about it so you don't have to waste energy remembering the info.

When someone clicks that "Sign Up" button, it pops open a quick form for them to put in their information, which is called an Instant Form on Meta. For this type of ad, the person simply puts in their email, and then an automation on the back-end sends a calendar event to their email calendar.

That's all the event ads do. We promote an event, and the call to action is simple: click the "Sign up" button on the ad, type in your email and we'll throw it on your calendar with reminders. If we remember back to the The Value-Friction Graph in Chapter 6 for asking organically, the concept still applies here. People will only put up with the friction of a CTA if it is worth it (i.e., if there is enough value). Here, the value is they get peace of mind for the event. They don't have

to worry about the details of the event, since all the details are sent to them and they get calendar reminders. That's enough value to justify putting in your email (and pro tip: Meta Forms auto-fill in their info so it's even easier for them).

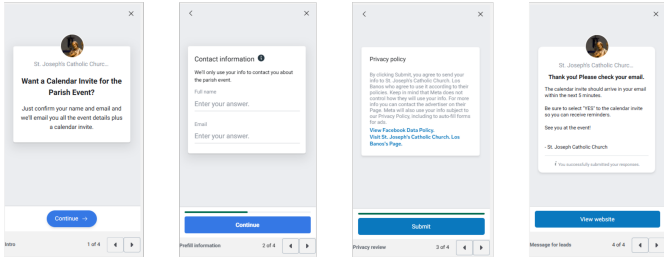
How to Set up the Instant Form For Event Ads

When I ran that ad above for a Corpus Christi Eucharistic Procession at St. Joseph's, the ad itself was fairly standard, and at first glance it looked like it was doing well. After one day, we had received 30 “Sign Up” clicks from local parishioners. That sounded like a great result! People were seeing the ad, responding to it, and tapping the button.

But there was one big problem. Only one person actually *completed* the form and submitted their name and email.

And when I saw that, it means only one thing: people wanted to respond to the ad, but there was too much friction after they tapped “Sign Up.” They were interested enough to click, but not interested enough to finish the process.

So I decided to review the Instant Form I made (see below).



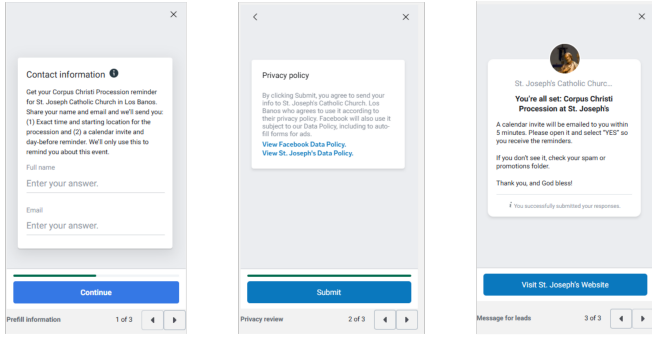
At first glance, I thought I set the form up to be pretty easy to complete. It had only four slides, and it was general enough that I could use it for almost any parish event. Then I remembered the Value-CTA Graph I explained in Chapter 6 of this book. The lower the friction, the more people respond.

So I decided to remove anything I could from the form. I found out that I can actually remove the Intro page from the form, so I did that. Instead of making people tap through an introduction, I sent them straight to the contact information page after they tapped "Sign Up." Any important introductory information was moved onto the contact page itself.

I also realized that some people might have been confused because the form was too general. Since I had designed it to work for any parish event, it did not clearly reflect the specific event they had just clicked on. So I updated the form to include the exact details for the Corpus Christi Eucharistic Procession.

Finally, I simplified the thank-you page. Instead of giving people a vague confirmation message, I gave them clear instructions on what to do next: check their email and click "Yes" on the calendar invite.

The revised form is shown below.



I published the new form and went to bed. The next morning, I opened Ads Manager to see if the change had worked. Overnight, we had received five new registrations from 15 additional "Sign Up" clicks! That means the completion rate increased from about 3% to 30%...a massive difference.

The ad itself did not change, nor did the audience change (Meta does not go back into training mode if only the Instant Forms are updated). The only thing that changed was the amount of friction in the form.

Based on that experience, here is the Instant Form framework I recommend for parish event ads:

1. Do not use an intro page. Send people straight to the contact information page.

2. Ask only for email (and maybe their name). Do not ask for extra information unless it is truly necessary.

3. Make the form specific to the event. Include the event name, date, time, and key details so people know exactly what they are signing up for.

4. Use a clear thank-you page. Tell people to check their email and click "Yes" on the calendar invite.

This works because Meta can auto-fill much of the person's information for them. In many cases, the parishioner does not have to type anything at all. They simply tap, confirm their information, and submit. And "just tapping" is the goal. The easier the form is to complete, the more people will complete it. And the more people complete it, the more people who show up to the event.

How to Send the Events to Their Calendar

Now that we understand how event ads work and how to set up the Instant Form, let's talk about what happens after someone clicks the ad and signs up.

Setting up the Meta ad account and building the ad itself is beyond the scope of this book. The exact steps for running ads change often, especially as Meta continues adding more AI tools. But the basic follow-up system stays the same. The system has three basic steps:

1. Send the person's name and email into a Google Sheet.

2. Create a Google Calendar event for the parish event.

3. Use an automation tool to invite each new person from the Google Sheet to the calendar event.

When someone taps the "Sign Up" button on your Meta ad and submits their name and email through the Instant Form, that information is stored inside Meta. Instead of manually checking Meta and copying each person's information, you can connect the form to a Google Sheet. You don't need to be a tech expert to do this, Meta

allows you to simply tap "Connect to a Google Sheet" before you run the ad. That way, every time someone signs up, their name and email automatically appear in a new row in the Sheet. This gives the parish a clean, simple list of everyone who expressed interest in the event.

Once the Google Sheet is connected, the next step is to create the actual Google Calendar event. Use a parish Gmail account for this so they are receiving an email from an account they trust, For example:

- marketing@stjohnsparish.com
- office@stjohnsparish.com
- stjohnssocialmedia@gmail.com

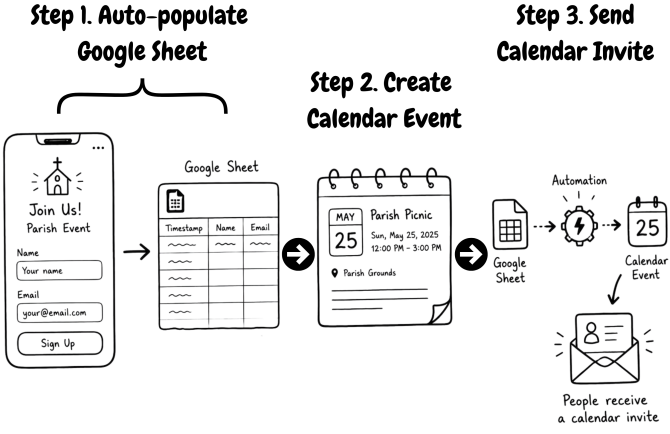
From that parish account, open Google Calendar and create the event. Add the event name, date, time, location, description, and any important details people need to know. I also recommend adding two reminders to the calendar event: one reminder 24 hours before the event and one reminder three hours before the event. At this point, you have two pieces in place: a Google Sheet filling up with names and emails, and a Google Calendar event ready to go. The final step is to connect them.

To do this, you will need a simple automation tool. My favorite automation tool for this is Zapier, which allows you to connect one app to another. In simple terms, it works like this: when something happens in one place, Zapier makes something happen somewhere else. In this case, the automation is:

- **Trigger:** A new person is added to the Google Sheet.
- **Action:** That person is invited to the Google Calendar event.

Zapier also has beginner-friendly setup tools, tutorials, and an AI assistant that can help you build the automation by typing what you want in plain English. For example, you could type: "When a new row is added to this Google Sheet, invite that email address to this Google Calendar event."

Once the automation is published, the system is ready. Now, when someone signs up through the Meta ad, their information is saved in the Google Sheet, and they automatically receive a calendar invite for the event. This piece is a must-have because now instead of hoping people remember the event, the parish gives them a simple reminder right where they already manage their schedule. You get more attendance, and they get to keep scrolling.



Volunteer Ads

Volunteer ads are ads where we're asking people if they're interested in helping out around the parish. This can be for serving in the choir, hospitality, children's ministry, tech, etc. In fact, you can run a volunteer ad for any ministry position in the parish.

The general structure of the volunteer ad is as follows. We run an advertisement asking for volunteers around the parish (like the young adult leader example in the previous chapter). They click a "Learn More" button on the ad that brings them to an Instant Form for them to fill out their contact info. Then, the parish reaches out just like they would with any other volunteer interest.

I find these to be much simpler than event ads, because there are no automations required. The contacting is manual, so there are no automations required (besides connecting the Instant Form to the Google Sheet). The Instant Forms setup is almost identical as well. The only difference to make in the volunteer ad compared to the event ad is to include a phone number field, in case the parish prefers to call them rather than email them.

How to Call/Text Interested People

They have given us permission to contact them, but we're not out of the woods yet: we still have to pre-qualify them and get them to show up for the position.

To pre-qualify the person, the best thing to do is call them and have a conversation with them. Now most people don't answer calls from strangers, so here is the structure I recommend following:

1. Call them within 24 hours of them giving their info (within 5 minutes is ideal)

2. If they answer, pre-qualify them

3. If they don't answer, leave a voicemail AND a text message

First, we want to call them within 24 hours because "speed-to-lead" is such a powerful driver of human decision making. Speed-to-lead refers to the idea that people are more motivated to keep taking action when those actions are closer together. If you try a free sample at Costco, and then leave and come back 2 months later, you probably won't buy the product. But if you try the free sample, and five seconds later the sample lady goes, "Would you like to try a small box? They're on sale..." you get the idea. Contact them within 24 hours so they don't lose their motivation and talk themselves out of it.

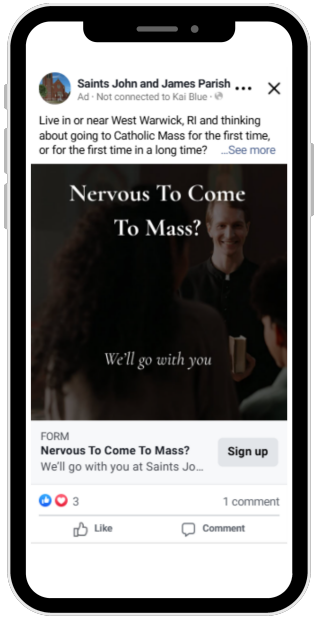
Second, we want to pre-qualify them. This should make sense, we don't just want *anyone* doing the readings at Mass, or being a catechist. There are a host of things you would want to know about the person before you let them take a volunteering role at the parish. This will vary role to role, and parishes already have a system for this, so I won't spend too much time on this. One thing I will mention is to ask about location, just to make sure they're from the area. It's possible they saw the ad driving through town, or when they were only visiting for the weekend.

Finally, we still want to chat with them if they don't answer. Leave a voicemail explaining why you're calling and tell them in the voicemail "I'll shoot you a quick text as well in case it's easier for you to text." Hang up, then text them what you said in the voicemail. Whether they call or text you back, continue the conversation in whichever medium they responded.

"First Mass" Ads

First Mass ads are for people who are maybe curious about the Catholic Faith, but are in that "on the fence" position, and likely won't walk into a Mass for the first time on their own. The goal is to lower the emotional barrier of walking into church, since many people are not opposed to coming to Mass; they simply do not want to walk in alone, feel confused, or wonder where to sit. It's just intimidating.

So, these ads solve that problem. The ad says share a bit about yourself and we'll have someone from the parish reach out and, if you'd like, meet you and sit with you at Mass. When the form comes in, a staff member (ideally a young adult leader) contacts them, learns their situation, and starts to befriend them so things don't feel so intimidating.



Text Script for Messaging "First Mass" People

One tool that's especially helpful for messaging people interested in coming to Mass for the first time is a script. A script is essentially a template conversation framework that allows you to systematize all of your conversations. This does not mean the conversation is robotic, but more so you're making sure to check certain boxes before moving them on to the next step. For example, every conversation should ask about where they live. Because, if for whatever reason they clicked on the ad but were only in town for the day, it wouldn't make sense to have them come to Mass (since they already left).

Here is the structure I like to follow:

- Introduction
    - Bubble 1: Hi [Name]! This is Joe from [Parish Name] in [City, State]. I was just speaking with [Pastor] and noticed you were interested in coming to Mass sometime! That's great to hear.
    - Bubble 2: Happy to help you out in any way I can. Mind if I ask you a couple questions?
- Confirm Location
    - Do you live in the [City] area?
- Confirm Interest
    - Curious, what got you interested in coming to Catholic Mass? If you don't mind me asking

- Hand-off to friend
    - Bubble 1: Well that's amazing. Honestly I think you'd fit right in with a lot of the young adults here at Mass. I can connect you with [Young Adult Ambassador]. If you'd like, he can meet you before Mass and sit with you so you don't have to go alone.
    - Bubble 2: Would you be open to a quick three-way group chat?

Then make a group chat and hand them off to the young adult team member who can start a relationship with them.

That's it. That's all you need to get outreach going and to get the ball rolling with new people.

Yes, people will back out. And people will show up once and never come back. But some people will stay. At the end of the day, you now have a systematized outreach system. And you can track the metrics, and change things and set goals...and that's something a lot of parishes don't have, but need.

What About Giving Campaigns?

There are also giving campaigns, and most parishes are familiar with these. If you're thinking, "Our biggest problem is the collection, so why not just run ads asking for money?" you're not crazy. Parishes do need money. I'm also *not* morally opposed to digital giving campaigns.

But I'm deliberately not explaining these campaigns in this book for one main reason: **money probably isn't the *root* issue.** It can feel like the root issue, believe me, but it's usually something upstream. If people are consistently engaging at a parish, and they're receiving value

and helping out and making friends, etc...they'll donate. Maybe not everyone, but most people.

The three ad lanes we *are* focusing on in this book all drive engagement:

Volunteer ads invite people into helping out around the parish more.

Event ads get people to show up to things.

And First Mass ads help people cross the most important line: showing up to your first Mass.

My recommendation would be this: if you are consistently growing volunteers, event attendance, and new parishioners, but money is still tight, *then* consider giving campaigns. But otherwise, start with these three campaigns.

To summarize, parish ads work best when they follow a simple three-ad system. Event ads help increase attendance. Volunteer ads help you get more volunteers. And first Mass ads help new people walk through the doors. When parishes run these three campaigns consistently, they stop guessing and start building a repeatable system for attendance, volunteers, and outreach.

Key Takeaways

- Parish ads should focus on three main goals: events, volunteers, and First Mass outreach.
- Event ads work best when the CTA is simple: tap, enter your email, and get the event on your calendar.
- Volunteer ads are similar to event ads, but the contacting is manual (not automatic)

- The less friction in the form, the more people will complete it.
- First Mass ads focus on reaching people outside of the parish bubble

Chapter Nine

The 1-3-10 Framework

My phone buzzed. Another text from a pastor.

"Hi Joe! Could we run an ad for this Friday for people to attend the Chrism Mass? Thank you."

I sighed. "Friday?" I thought to myself. "It's already Wednesday. Why weren't we running this two weeks ago?"

My frustration had been growing the last few weeks with more and more immediate requests coming through from the parishes I was helping. I felt like every day I was waking up without knowing what was going to come through the pipeline. And when requests did come through, the deadlines were short. I was getting exhausted, and I knew I couldn't keep doing this.

It was easy enough to run advertisements when the parishes gave me ample notice, but I found myself more and more often throwing up ads in a pinch, barely giving the ad time to get out of training mode and actually perform properly. I decided I needed to seek out some help.

About two years ago, I purchased a "Marketing AI Bot" from A cquisition.com, a private equity company that specialized in marketing. It was an AI chatbot that was trained on a whole bunch of cutting-edge marketing materials. I found it to be quite helpful when I was stuck thinking of a heading for a post or a title for a YouTube video. So, I decided to hop in there and vent my frustrations.

I laid out my "Standard Operating Procedure" for running ads for parishes, which at that time was to basically wait until the parish told me they wanted to promote something and then I'd build a campaign and run an advertisement for it. I fed the bot all the details on the types of ads, and their average budgets, etc. and then asked it to help me solve my core problem: how do I figure out a system here that I can implement across all parishes so I'm not running around all day? And after some back and forth, it produced an answer.

An answer that saved me so many potential headaches and hours of time.

"Don't run multiple campaigns for multiple different ads. Run one campaign with all of the ads inside of it. The budget will spread out across all the ads. When events end or volunteering positions are filled, rinse and repeat with new ones."

It was so obviously simple, but there was still the minor problem of knowing when the events were coming. "But what if the parish asks me to promote an event with short notice? Then I'm back to scrambling."

"Have each parish tell you the most important upcoming events 60 days out, every month," it said.

That seemed reasonable enough to me. I can just ask the office admin to send me all of these events or important liturgies ahead of time, and I can "queue them up" so to speak in the single ad campaign.

I implemented it immediately across all my clients. The results were amazing. I was able to run multiple ads simultaneously while keeping

ad spend the same. And even more exciting, I had peace of mind not having to run around putting together campaigns at a moment's notice.

I finally nailed an ads strategy that works across all parishes. I call it the 1-3-10 Framework.

The 1-3-10 Framework

The 1-3-10 Framework works like this:

- **1 campaign (and ad set)**
- **3 ads**
- **$10 per day in ad spend (total)**

We covered the three different types of ads in the last chapter. In this chapter we'll learn how to actually set up the system.

For most parishes starting out, the simplest setup is one Lead Campaign, one ad set, three ads, and a small daily budget. It is not the only possible structure, but it is simple, affordable, and easy to manage.

1 Campaign

The campaign in Meta Ads Manager is where you select what the goal is. For us, our goal is acquiring leads, so we're going to run a Lead Campaign. A lead, in business terms, is a person that has shown interest in what you're doing and have given you their contact information. They haven't reached the finish line so to speak, but they've expressed interest in taking the next step.

All of the ad types we've discussed: event ads, volunteer ads, and "First Mass" ads, are all essentially trying to get people to express

interest. Therefore, we can run all of the ads under a single Lead Campaign. The benefit of this is that we can choose to distribute the ad spend across all of the ads. For example, if a parish spends $10/day on advertising costs in Meta, that $10/day will be spread across the event ad, the volunteer ad, and the First Mass ad.

3 Ads

Next, run one each of the three ads simultaneously. Doing this allows the parish to continuously promote for volunteers, events, and new parishioners as a sort of "slow burn." The spend is distributed amongst them, and there are local people consistently seeing invitations to do things at the parish. This removes the chaos of having to switch between marketing needs or quickly throwing something up on the Facebook feed. It just runs and produces results.

I recommend running three ads at a time because if you run significantly more, the spend struggles to spread across all of the ads and it is difficult to get consistent results. And if you run less than three, the ads will fatigue quicker and it will be more operational work to "swap them out" all the time. In many local parish audiences, ads may start to fatigue after a couple of weeks, so I recommend reviewing performance every two weeks and swapping out weaker creatives as needed.

Every month, ask the parish office to send the most important events, volunteer needs, and outreach priorities for the next 60 days. This gives you enough time to build ads before the deadline becomes urgent. It also lets you rotate creatives calmly instead of scrambling when someone texts you three days before an event.

$10 per Day in Ad Spend (Total)

Finally, you set the budget to **$10 per day** for the whole campaign. Meta will automatically push more of that $10 toward whichever of the three lanes is currently getting the cheapest leads. That's fine. All three are good for the parish. If you have a big focus week (for example, a Lenten mission), you can **pause the other two ad sets** so all $10 goes to Events for that period.

Over a month, $10 per day is about $300. Many parishes already spend that on printing, mailings, and things people barely see. Here, you're trading that money for **guaranteed reach** to the right local people with clear invitations. In my experience, $10/day is usually enough to generate meaningful local reach for a parish within a 15–20-mile radius. For most parishes, that's a sufficient slow burn.

Putting Everything Together

You now have the core frameworks you need to run parish social media with clarity. Let's do a quick recap.

For organic social media—posts that are free to post—you want to follow the H.A.C.S. framework on a weekly cadence. Each week, the parish should post a homily clip, an activity post from around the parish, a connection post, and use the Stories to promote events or volunteering (one-three Stories per week is sufficient).

For paid social media—posts that cost money—you want to follow the 1-3-10 framework. Run one campaign with three ads at $10/day. As the ads fatigue, swap them out with new creatives, which will probably happen every couple of weeks.

To use this book effectively, start implementing these two frameworks today, and reference the specific chapter in areas where you get stuck.

Thank you for reading, and for wanting to grow and learn more. Most of all, thank you for being willing to help spread the Catholic Faith to more people. God bless you, and please know I am praying for you.

-Joe

Chapter Ten

A Next Step

Want All This Done At Your Parish?

If you found this book useful, I'm glad. As you may know, I have a company that helps Catholic churches implement systems to reach and engage young adults. We manage your parish social media for you and run local campaigns to promote events and invite new young adults to Mass. You stay focused on ministry while we handle the posts, ads, and tracking what actually works.

Catholic Priests: If that sounds interesting to you, go to **www.chapellaunch.com** and book a free consultation for your parish. We'll look at your current online presence, map out a simple growth plan, and you can decide if you want us to implement it for you.

Scan the QR Code Below to Book a Free Consultation for Your Parish